

Block

2

PSYCHOLOGICAL THEORIES

UNIT 5**Selectivity Theories****5**

UNIT 6**Individual Difference Theory****19**

UNIT 7**Persuasion and Attitude****33**

UNIT 8**Theories of Learning****49**

EXPERTS COMMITTEE

Prof. B.P.Sanjay Former VC, CUTN; PVC, Univ. of Hyderabad, Hyderabad	Prof. J.S. Yadav Former Director, IIMC New Delhi	Prof. B.K. Kuthiala Former VC, MLCRPV, Bhopal
Prof. G. Ravindran Head, Department of Communication, University of Madras, Chennai	Prof. Kiran Thakur Former Head, Deptt. of Communication & Journalism, Savitribai Phule Pune University, Pune	Prof. Usha Raman S. N. School of Arts & Communication, University of Hyderabad Hyderabad
Mr. Shastri Ramachandran, Editor and Columnist New Delhi	Prof. Iftekhhar Ahmed Director, MCRC, Jamia Milia Islamia, New Delhi	Prof. Jaishri Jethwaney Former Head, ADPR IIMC, New Delhi
Prof. Usha Rani Former Head, Deptt. of Comm. & Journalism Mysore University	Ms Sevanti Ninan Senior Journalist & Founder Editor, The Hoot, New Delhi	Ms Pamela Philipose Senior Journalist and Author, New Delhi
Ms Mahalakshmi Jayaram. Senior Dy. Editor, The Hindu, Chennai	Prof. Biswajit Das Director, CCMG, Jamia Milia Islamia, New Delhi	Prof. Gita Bamezai Head Dept. of Comm. Research, IIMC New Delhi
Dr. Vipul Mudgal Senior Journalist and Author, New Delhi	Prof. Madhu Parhar Director, STRIDE IGNOU	Mr. K. Ravikanth Director, EMPC IGNOU
Prof. Subhash Dhuliya Former Director SOJNMS, IGNOU	Prof. Shambhu Nath Singh Former Director SOJNMS, IGNOU	Dr. O. P. Dewal Associate Professor, SOJNMS, IGNOU
Dr. Kiron Bansal Associate Professor SOJNMS, IGNOU	Dr. K.S. Arul Selvan Associate Professor SOJNMS, IGNOU	Dr. Ramesh Yadav Assistant Professor, SOJNMS, IGNOU
Dr. Shikha Rai Assistant Professor SOJNMS, IGNOU	Dr. Amit Kumar Assistant Professor SOJNMS, IGNOU	Ms. Padmini Jain Assistant Professor, SOJNMS, IGNOU

PROGRAMME AND COURSE COORDINATOR:

Dr. Ramesh Yadav, Associate Professor, SOJNMS, IGNOU, New Delhi

BLOCK PREPARATION TEAM

Unit 5	Dr. Asha Krishnaswamy Independent Journalist, Bangaluru	Content Editor: Prof. N.Usha Rani Former Prof. & Head Dept. of Journalism & Mass Communication Mysore University, Mysore
Unit 6:	Prof H. S. Eswara Former Chairperson & Dean Faculty of Communication, Bangalore University Bengaluru	
Unit 7&8:	Prof. K. V. Nagaraj Former Prof. Deptt. of Mass Communication Mizoram University, Aizawl Mizoram	Block Editor: Dr. Kiron Bansal Associate Professor SOJNMS, IGNOU

PRODUCTION TEAM

Mr. Rajive Girdhar Asst. Registrar MPDD, IGNOU, New Delhi	Mr. Hemant Parida Section Officer MPDD, IGNOU, New Delhi
---	--

February, 2023

© Indira Gandhi National Open University, 2023

ISBN:

All rights reserved. No part of this work may be reproduced in any form, by mimeograph or any other means, without permission in writing from the Indira Gandhi National Open University.

Further information on the Indira Gandhi National Open University courses may be obtained from the University's office at Maidan Garhi, New Delhi.

Printed and published on behalf of the Indira Gandhi National Open University, New Delhi by the Registrar, MPDD, IGNOU, New Delhi.

Laser Typeset by Tessa Media & Computers, C-206, A.F.E.-II, Okhla, New Delhi.

Printed at:

BLOCK INTRODUCTION : PSYCHOLOGICAL THEORIES

This is the second block of the Course **MDC-006: Media and Communication Theories**. There are four units in this block and each unit addresses major theoretical concepts related by broad psychological perspective.

Unit 5: Selectivity Theories deals with Selective usage of content and helps in understanding how individuals seek information and appreciate information which usually reinforces their beliefs. It poses issues of how people seek information from media and is it influenced by their pre-existing beliefs on the subject. It also discusses related theories of cognitive dissonance and social comparison theories besides mood management theory to help you understand the element of bias in selecting and understanding news.

Unit 6: Individual Difference Theory argues that different personality variables, such as intelligence, beliefs, values, perceptibility etc. result in different reactions to the same stimuli. Building on selectivity theories, this theory prepares ground for understanding the psychology of individual differences and gives new ideas for research and project works.

Unit 7: Persuasion and Attitude is all you wanted to know about mass media influence. As a content producer of media, you should know what factors influence audience to accept and adopt media messages whether it is buying a product or accepting certain health behaviour.

Unit 8: Theories of Learning is a psychological theory that has created voluminous research on learning theories. It helps you understand the dominance of mediated communication in everyday life of students in a media saturated world. You can practically apply this theory to your process of learning in new technology mediated environment using new media.

All units in this block have common theme of human behaviour under the umbrella of psychological theories and hence makes it easy to apply the concepts to your relationships with media whether it is learning in the classroom or using social media. It is advisable to study the units in a sequence as one finds reference to selectivity theory in all the subsequent units and strengthen your broad understanding of the psychological process in communication.

We hope that you will enjoy studying this Block and develop a good understanding of the concepts and perspectives discussed.

UNIT 5 SELECTIVITY THEORIES

Structure

- 5.0 Introduction
- 5.1 Learning Outcomes
- 5.2 Key Elements and their Relationship
 - 5.2.1 Selectivity and Understanding
 - 5.2.2 Selectivity and Biases
 - 5.2.3 Selectivity and Matching Beliefs
 - 5.2.4 Silo Mentality
 - 5.2.5 Purposes Served through Selective Communication
- 5.3 Selective Process and Related Theories
 - 5.3.1 Cognitive Dissonance Theory
 - 5.3.2 Socioemotional Selectivity Theory and Family Communication
 - 5.3.3 Reinforcement Theory
 - 5.3.4 Social Comparison Theory
 - 5.3.5 Mood Management Theory
- 5.4 Core Concepts
 - 5.4.1 Selectivity Theories: Essential Features
 - 5.4.2 Selectivity Process: Exposure, Perception, and Retention
 - 5.4.3 Selectivity Theories and Information Processing
 - 5.4.4 Techniques of Measuring Selective Exposure
 - 5.4.5 Selective Exposure Research
- 5.5 Let Us Sum Up
- 5.6 Further Readings
- 5.7 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

5.0 INTRODUCTION

In the previous Block you were exposed to Sociological Theories which explored the relationship between mass communication and society. This Block explains the importance of psychological concepts vital in understanding how we communicate with each other and what are the factors that influence the way the messages are perceived, understood and accepted. The psychological approach to understanding communication gave rise to many theories which include Selectivity theories, Individual Difference theory, Persuasion and Attitude and Theories of Learning; which will be discussed in this Block.

Selection by individuals is a mental process. Individuals seek information and appreciate information which usually reinforces their beliefs. The tendency is to avoid those information or propaganda material contradicting their beliefs. Human beings evolve and personalities get developed based on various factors including experiences, emotions and sometimes due to pressure from society. All these are cognition (mental) process and related to thinking. The study of selectivity and the theories related to it are closely linked to psychology.

Selective Theories have debunked powerful effects of mass communication and theories related to it. Selective in seeing, reading, forming perception, disseminating information, grouping, socialising and communicating is the tendency in individuals as well as those who are into communication business and management. Mass communication has narrowed down to selective communication as receivers have become choosy when it comes to reading/viewing/listening content from mass media as the dissemination process has become technology dependent and forums are many.

Social media platforms have been playing a major role in the selective dissemination of opinions, news, information, analysis and firming up opinions. There are formal and informal methods to disseminate selective communication. Stimuli play a crucial role in adopting a selective process. In this Unit, we shall discuss various types of Selective Theories, the reasons for individuals/organisations to be selective in their understanding and communicating.

5.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading through this unit, you should be able to:

- describe the stages of Selective Attention, Selective Exposure, Selective Perception, and Selective Retention;
- discuss Selective Information Processing;
- explain the role of stimuli in Selective Process; and
- analyse the effect of Selective Attention and Communication.

5.2 KEY ELEMENTS AND THEIR RELATIONSHIPS

Selective process includes selective interest, selective perception, selective retention, and selective dispersion of beliefs or arguments among others. It is like a person having the capacity or ability to understand, retain and send communication or messages while ignoring the rest. In Selectivity Theories, culture also plays a prominent role. The selective process helps an individual by endorsing pre-existing beliefs whatever could be the situation.

Let us try to understand how selectivity works in communication.

5.2.1 Selectivity and Understanding

In simple terms, it can be referred to as a psychological activity. An individual arranges sensory stimuli s/he receives from their surroundings. One becomes very choosy while imagining or understanding subjects or issues. For example, if you like a film actor, however bad her movies are, you tend to watch her on screen and support her. In addition, you try to ignore the demerits in her movies. You may also not like to see movies of other actors who could be as talented or more talented than her. You keep voting for a particular political party because it suits your beliefs or leanings. This liking is developed for the party though you might not have analysed whether the party has lived up to its electoral promises or philosophies it has advocated. Another simple example is - you may develop a dislike for an individual just because s/he is a tobacco consumer.

Perceptions are formed selectively based on what an individual sees, hears and reads which supports or endorses one's views. Such selectivity could lead to favouritism, in addition, one may miss seeing or hearing other healthy views. Even facts, figures, information, and knowledge could be missed out if one does not have an open mind.

5.2.2 Selectivity and Biases

This is nothing but viewing the world selectively. People who have strong likes, dislikes and opinions will be biased in their perception. They tend to notice what they want to believe. They may ignore the beliefs that contradict their opinions or views. Such biased viewed people keep nurturing their beliefs by remaining selective in their thought process. For example, if you believe that a particular king hated a section of society based on their religion, then you would not like to get a comprehensive view of the works done by the king during his time. Any number of history books would fail to make you understand the facts about the regime of the king. If you like a particular city just because you are born and brought up there you develop a positive bias towards that place.

Biases are formed based on one's pick and choose the way of observing, hearing and understanding subjects or issues or people. Sometimes the process of selection may lack logic. However, it is difficult to counter one's biases. Such biases in the communication field are not good. Biased beliefs lead to the propagation of a certain school of thinking, distribution of ideas, ideologies, and content in the media. If a journalist is biased, then s/he will be selective in what s/he wants to produce as content and selective in talking to sources, which will suit his/her perceptions.

Biases are also viewed as positive and negative though these terms could be subjective. For example, if you are biased towards a national leader who always preferred peace to war, then you have a positive bias. However, there could be dissent voice saying that that the leader took a wrong decision and thus caused more damage to his/her country.

5.2.3 Selectivity and Matching Beliefs

People purposefully select messages and information that match their beliefs. It is a psychological process. A lot of research has been carried out to find as to why and how the selection process takes place. The common man and media consumers are choosy in receiving content. It is easy to filter contents which they like to receive rather than receiving all types of content. Why do people incline towards selecting congenial messages? There could be several reasons for being choosy.

Cognitive selection or exposure, seeking only information that suits their convenience, getting motivated to prefer certain things, requires less cognitive effort to for processing information. Moods too influence selection. Several reasons may work at a time or only one reason could be the contributing factor. Human cognition has its own limitation. When there is a wealth of information or chaotic information, then it is for people to be selective and thus tread the path they like to. Otherwise, they would be wasting their time and effort in processing all the available information.

If you like a particular spiritual leader, then you will be selecting and collecting all the information about the leader. In addition, you will look for people who have beliefs similar to yours. You will start liking such people and bond with them. If an editor of a media house believes that a particular infrastructure project is not planned scientifically, then s/he will make the editorial team to reflect his/her likes and dislikes. S/he will choose writers who endorse his opinion and write accordingly. S/he will also tailor edits and opinion pieces which match one's outlook on the infrastructure project. S/he may not be ready to develop a comprehensive look towards the project due to the prejudices.

5.2.4 Silo Mentality

The dictionary meaning of 'silo' is a large structure which is usually cylindrical and functions as a storing structure. In business organisations, silo mentality is becoming common and a problem too. In the business world, silo mentality means departments within an organisation not sharing information with others in the same organisation. Companies which are into news business and organisations which are into dispersing information also have a silo mentality. In this e-era, probably all news organisations are receiving and dispersing news and infotainment content via new media inclusive of social media platforms.

Companies and organisations which are into designing content create media silos by monitoring content browsed, tweeted and posts on facebook by media employees. On a daily basis, information snippets, newsletters, and press notes are sent by companies, organisations and political parties. In a way, it is pushing only certain type of news and information on individuals. In such situations, media persons may not miss any information in a particular subject but they may miss a broader picture due to the narrow approach. Media silos could make lose the ability to analyse and develop a broader perspective.

In newsrooms, silo mentality is not uncommon. Media persons working in isolation, leads to duplication of work or creating parallel content. In media rooms, there will be different sections which have to work in unison. Usually, the tendency among journalists is not to discuss the stories on which they are working, with others. This is to maintain exclusivity. The present trend is that media houses are having divergent platforms - like newspapers, magazines, news tabloids, news websites and videos in different languages. They are also active on social media platforms like Facebook and Twitter. When there are major developments, each section will have to create content about the developments. If journalists who are at it hold discussions among themselves, then they can avoid duplication of work or parallel content creation. This would also help in putting out information quickly. Even contradictory information from a single media house on different platforms could be avoided.

A media house could be generating content in multiple languages. If content produced in one language could be translated into other languages, then a lot of resources and time could be saved. Social media platforms may take a couple of lines, while web editions can be longer versions. Such news pooling system has made beginning in India. But media management is trying to tackle this silo mentality at different levels.

5.2.5 Purposes Served through Selective Communication

Selective communication serves both positive and negative purposes. In a complex environment, selective communication process can help in selecting content which supports the pre-existing beliefs. This makes the selection itself easier. For example, during elections, newspapers offer a lot of information. If you have no time or interest to read all the reports despite you like electoral politics, then you will read news regarding the party or leader/s whom you like while leaving the rest. This may help you in reinforcing your belief in party or individual. This would also help in getting more information about the subject you like. The pitfall is that you leave out the rest of the news though it could be interesting and useful to develop a comprehensive look towards elections.

Selective communication helps in spreading and imposing one's beliefs and views on others. Companies which are into marketing products and services, political parties and celebrities tend to make best of selective communication techniques. It is like a one-way traffic in which unmindful of receivers' likes and dislikes, information is given. Sometimes the receivers may be influenced. At the same time, they may develop strong dislike too. There are dangers of developing assumptions while consuming selective content. It can also lead to developing sympathy, rightly or wrongly.

It is common to see selective communication by media houses. With big multinational companies and politicians entering the media field, selective communication is becoming a common feature. It is difficult to find a media house which has no biases and not indulging in selective news communication.

Check Your Progress 1

Notes: 1) Tick the correct answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

- a) Human thought process and behaviour is.....
 Erratic Good Incoherent Consistent
- b) Selectivity process is
 Biological Financial limitation Psychological
 None of these
- c) Attitudes are an important aspect of cognition.....
 Wrong Right Partially right Motive Pattern
- d) Biases are viewed as
 Positive Negative Positive & Negative
 Partially Positive & Negative
- e) Silo mentality in media
 Good for media houses Leads to waste of resources
 Leads to getting broader perspective Is not at all common

- 2) Write a brief note on purposes served through selective communication.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

- 3) Explain what silo mentality means in media context.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

5.3 SELECTIVE PROCESS AND RELATED THEORIES

There are several communication theories and some are inter-related. Some theories could be understood better if related theories are read and understood. Hence, here some related theories are being explained.

5.3.1 Cognitive Dissonance Theory

The word cognition has many meanings like comprehension, attention, awareness, observation, perception etc., while dissonance means disagreement. In psychology, cognitive dissonance is explained as the mental discomfort experienced by a person who simultaneously holds more than one contradictory beliefs, ideas, ideologies, arguments or values. The discomfort is because s/he is confronted with content which could be diametrically opposite to the beliefs or opinion s/he has. It is a thought conflict process. This theory was first proposed by US psychologist Leon Festinger in the 1950s. It was an attempt to link attitude with behaviour. Cognitive dissonance has the capacity to alter people's thinking and attitude. Attitude can influence behaviour.

If you consider yourself rational, you will try to match your behaviour with your thinking. If you are in the habit of drinking too much coffee a day despite knowing caffeine can lead to ill health, you will try to set aside those hard facts and advocate how coffee can function as a stimulant to elevate mood. By saying so, you try to reduce or rationalise the dissonance quickly. One of the positive effects of it helps in easing tension caused because of the facts. It brings back stability to mind quickly because the action is justified rightly and wrongly.

Cognitive dissonance can lead to problems when your beliefs are shaken through some act or words. Inconsistency can lead to mental stress. To get back to normalcy one may have to change their beliefs, actions or change the perception of actions.

If you go on brooding over the caffeine effect, then you have to give up your habit. That is like giving up your belief that coffee is not harmful to health.

People continue to seek information on subjects of their likings or which support their beliefs. So the selectivity theory has roots in the cognitive dissonance theory.

5.3.2 Socioemotional Selectivity Theory and Family Communication

According to socioemotional selectivity, older adults develop increased positivity in attention and recall. This is because as they get older, they believe their lifespan is getting reduced and thus develop positivity in paying attention and recalling incidents. As people age, they focus more on enjoying the life to the full and nurture existing relationships. However, experiments are still taking place to arrive at conclusions.

Positive retention and recall also mean biases in information processing. In contrast to older people, younger adults prioritise knowledge and social goals because they have to walk to future with goals and meet various challenges. They are ready to experiment and explore. Hence adults and youngsters have a different approach towards selecting what they see, hear, retain, recall, analyse and pursue social goals.

Communication shapes up families and members of families. Within a family communication takes place which leads to image formation, cohesion, learning, understanding, misunderstanding, bonding, power centers, beliefs, endorsement of beliefs etc. When two individuals come together in a marriage, their beliefs and principles in life could be different. While one may be an atheist and another may be an agnostic. Such beliefs could be because of the influence of their parents, elders in the family, debates, and discussions that take place within a family. Even the culture of families is passed on from generation to generation. Belief in the family system and family values could be rooted in environment in which one grows up. So based on the beliefs they grow up, they become selective in thinking, consumption, and communication.

5.3.3 Reinforcement Theory

Communication theorist Joseph Kapler's Reinforcement Theory says that the media has limited power to influence people. It can only reinforce the pre-existing attitudes and beliefs. He argued that a person's belief and attitude is more shaped up by family, friends, educational institutions, religion, society at large and stimuli. The media at the most reinforce than change, he argued. However, when a new idea is floated by the media, it may catch the attention of the audience. People usually look for and remember information that provides support to their pre-existing attitudes and beliefs. The media make use of this process by trying to provide what audience like and believe rather than trying to change their beliefs and attitudes. In other words, media houses reinforce what the audience already believes. Generally, there are two types of reinforcement – positive and negative. Both could be productive.

A reader of a newspaper would pick and choose political news which goes well with his/her belief or ideology. Rarely will s/he make an attempt to read content which contradicts ones strong opinion and belief. However, if bombarded with such messages over a period, s/he may change his/her beliefs slowly.

5.3.4 Social Comparison Theory

Social Comparison Theory was proposed by social psychologist Leon Festinger in the 1950s. It mainly says that every individual has an urge to gain accurate self-evaluation. It could be his talent to sing, play sports, in academics or social status. This naturally leads them to compare themselves with others. This process can also lead to self-enhancement. But later many other researchers argued that comparison is done with socially upward categories too. The media has been found to play a pivotal role in social comparisons. Such comparisons can leave both positive and negative influence.

Advertisements in the media make the best use of tendency of humans to compare themselves with others. Even social media platforms which push advertisements are trying to make business through ads which fuel one's urge for comparisons. A junior woman athlete may read a story about a woman winning a gold medal at an international competition and admire her. At the same time, the junior athlete may keep the winner as the role model and practice better. An advertisement about the launch of a new bike may make someone who has an old bike to aspire for possessing a new vehicle or make one feel disappointed if one's financial resources do not permit to go for it.

5.3.5 Mood Management Theory

Leon Festinger's Cognitive Dissonance Theory becomes the base to understand Mood Management Theory. Festinger says that dissonance is produced when a person has two opposite cognitions. But it can be reduced through selective exposure to content. Mood Management theory discusses the ways a person selects media which helps in getting motivated or intensify or remain in a positive mood and thus help in managing the mood. If a person is in a happy state of mind, s/he may like to consume news or content from the media, which can further elevate mood. S/he may like to read about achievers, food outlets, and discount sales in malls or travel tips.

Playing on gadgets, reading advertisements, social comparisons by reading content or viewing also assists in mood management. If a person is depressed or bored, s/he can get inspired by reading positive reports. Even oral or written communication can help in managing the mood better. While doing so, one invariably becomes selective in choosing content or the mode.

Check Your Progress 2

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) Tick the right answers

a) Joseph Kapler's Reinforcement Theory says:

Media has a lot of power to influence people.

Media has no role at all in influencing people.

Media has limited power to influence people.

Media can be a powerful influencer but not doing it.

- b) For Mood Management Theory the base is

It is an independent theory

It is based on Sigmund Freud theories

Leon Festinger's cognitive dissonance theory

Social comparison theory

- 2) Define briefly cognitive concept with respect to media.
3) Name any three theories of selectivity.

5.4 CORE CONCEPTS

Every normal individual, knowingly or unknowingly, is selective in his/her decisions. Some are conscious decisions and some may not be so. In communication field, selectivity plays a key role. Psychologists and communication theorists have done a lot of research to give a theoretical perspective to selectivity, communication and connecting the two. Understanding the fundamentals of these two aspects makes it easier to communicate effectively.

5.4.1 Selectivity Theories: Essential Features

As the name suggests, the theories discuss the selectivity process adopted by individuals. At every stage in life, while taking decisions, whether major or minor, selection plays a role. It could be to read a book, to eat food, to watch a movie or plan travel — at all stages, thought process goes into it where choices could be available and options are made. If there is exposed information, then people tend to choose content based on their personal likes, advantage, prejudices and to reinforce their beliefs.

Selective usage of content or information or reading or viewing is what interests communication field including the media. It serves in understanding what kind of content is liked or disliked by the audience. This helps in designing content. There is a much technical support system to know the priorities of audiences, accordingly, content is pushed, especially on the Internet-based media.

Perceptions, attention, attitudes, moods, cognitive structure, expectations, opinions, beliefs, arguments, advocacy, repeated listening, repeated viewing, self-concept, and usage of stimuli are all essential features of selectivity.

5.4.2 Selectivity Process: Exposure Perception, and Retention

Attitude Change theories propounded by Paul Lazarsfeld, Joseph Klapper, DeFleur and Leon Festinger argued that Attitude Change process involves three forms of selectivity;

- Selective Exposure
- Selective Perception
- Selective Retention

Let us look at them in some detail.

People have a tendency to seek or favour information or content which endorses or reinforces their already existing views/beliefs. They usually avoid information that contradicts their views. This is termed Selective Exposure. People develop different attitudes towards media that promotes for example, a certain political ideology.

Perceptions are formed due to various factors including attitudes, likes, dislikes, beliefs etc. Each person perceives or becomes aware of what they want to while reading or sourcing messages in media, reading, listening to talks or discussions. Such people tend to ignore opposing views. This process is termed as Selective Perception, for example attitude towards sexual orientation, transgenders, lesbians gays and so on.

Selective Retention is what one retains/remembers after perceiving content received as media message. Each individual likes to retain what they like. If loads of advice is heard by students, they retain or remember what appeals to them most. The process of sieving and retaining is influenced by many factors. Selective retention leads to Selective Recall of words and actions. Personally we tend to remember those moments that are dearest/closest to our beliefs. But we also remember horrible and bitter experiences that have strongly impacted our lives. This selectivity process leads individuals to resist information with which they don't agree. It is a reinforcement theory invariably studied in political communication.

5.4.3 Selectivity Theories and Information Processing

Information processing is the epicentre of cognitive psychology. Individual is a processor of information like a computer. The human mind, as per cognitive psychology, processes information received called input and produces an output. It passes through recognition, attention and memory stages. It is selective attention based on attentional theory, which answers the common question of how our attention is drawn to one subject ignoring others at the same time. Simultaneously our mental system is capable of switching our attention from one to many. Psychologists argue that human mental system can process only a limited amount of information that they receive and not all. Information processing is of two types: firstly, Serial Processing where the mental system processes one information at a time and do not take all simultaneously. Secondly, parallel processing is a dual task technique where all processes occur simultaneously.

Information available can work as stimuli, and at the end, there would be a response. If you see a beautiful face of a kid on a television screen, if you have the mindset to watch it and appreciate it, then you will remember the image for a short period or long term. In the end, you may react to the image you see and keep recollecting it. To explain it scientifically, the eyes receive visual information and due to electric neural activity, information received is coded which finally goes to the brain where it gets stored. The output could be memory, attention, perception, retention, and recall. From seeing the image to processing it is a selective activity. Human information processing is interactive and is a mental process and it happens in stages.

5.4.4 Techniques of Measuring Selective Exposure

People do not pay attention on all the content offered by the media because they are choosy due to various reasons, as explained earlier. Audience of the media

are not consistent in their selection of content. Mood, requirements, current values, intentions and tastes; direct audience to decide their choices. Same is the approach for reading or viewing news and advertisements. While a lot of research has taken place to understand the selective approach, some tech-based tools have been designed to understand and measure selective exposure. With the tendency to consume online content growing globally, a good number of software tools have been developed to assess the exposure and consumption patterns. This helps in the promotion of business, in particular advertisements.

Selective exposure has been tested in a number of studies. One such study by Brain E. Weeks et.al (2017) pertains to modelling citizen's online political behaviour with selective exposure and incidental exposure to political information. Using a two-wave panel survey method, the study has tested the potential of selective exposure with that of incidental exposure to understand how they impact political information sharing on social media. The study points out that 'there is no universal path to sharing, but rather sharing, selective or incidental, depends on both individual characteristics and nature of the information environment' (Weeks et.al, 2017).

Studies have been conducted on selective exposure with emphasis on partisan selective exposure of political information in media. Early research revealed that selective exposure theory explained the factors responsible for limited effects of media on people's beliefs. Research tradition has shown that if people's beliefs are not challenged there will be no reason for people to change their beliefs. Media either changes or reinforces people's beliefs is the premise of this theory. Today, selective exposure research has advanced to test premises that contradict earlier beliefs (Stroud, 2010). Researchers argue that 'selective exposure may serve as an important predictor of media effects', in contrast to limited effects theory implying that the selective exposure does not indicate limited effects.

5.4.5 Selective Exposure Research

Psychologists Jonathan L Freedman and David O Sears, in their study on selective exposure, have reanalysed prevalent theories. People get exposed to a wide range of information. Despite this, it is difficult to change the pre-existing beliefs of people who hold strong opinions.

Selective Exposure research has received scholarly attention. One of the prominent areas of research is in the areas of selective exposure and polarisation (Stroud, 2010). The studies have shown that partisan selective exposure leads to polarisation and vice versa, meaning polarisation leads to selective exposure too showing reversal causal direction and has been tested in the area of political information. Researchers argue and believe that 'partisan selective exposure and polarisation may spark more political participation – a democratically desirable goal (cited in Stroud, 2010).

Communication professor R Kelly Garrett in his research argued that people do prefer to get political information though it may not go on the lines of their beliefs. They may not avoid opinions which challenge their selective likings and beliefs. A telephonic data collection done regarding a US presidential election showed that Americans used online information sources to get more information to opinions consistent with their own views while not ignoring views which contradicted their opinions. This finding contradicted the reinforcement theory.

But such an approach to information is needed for democratic election system. This argument could apply to commercial products too. If a person believes in allopathic medicines only, s/he may be ready to read information on other systems of medicine too.

Check Your Progress 3

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) Match the following

A	B
a) Attitude is	Computer processing
b) Perception is	Perception
c) Information processing in mind is like	An internal factor
d) Selective Retention follows	Way something is regarded

2) Write a brief note on the following:

- Selective Attention
- Selective Retention
- Selective Recall

5.5 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we discussed that to understand psychological perspectives in communication, understanding the established theories would help. Selective attention, selective recall, selective retention, attitudes, components of attitudes, cognitive process and the related subjects form the study of selectivity.

We examined theories that show the psychological process of information processing by human mind. Communication theorist Joseph Klapper's Reinforcement Theory says that the media has limited power to influence people. According to socioemotional selectivity, older adults develop increased positivity in attention and recall. In psychology, cognitive dissonance is explained as the mental discomfort experienced by a person who simultaneously holds more than one contradictory beliefs. Mood Management theory discusses the ways a person select media which helps in getting motivated or intensify or remain in a positive mood and thus help in managing the mood. Attitude change process involves three forms of selectivity namely Selective Exposure, Selective Perception and Selective Retention.

An in-depth reading and understanding of the research is essential to understand selectivity in media.

5.6 FURTHER READINGS

Baran, Stanley & Davis K.Dennis (2006), Mass Communication Theory: Foundations, Ferment and Future, Thomson Wadsworth

DeFleur, L.Melvin, (2010) Mass Communication Theories, Routledge

Johnson - Cartee, S. Karen & Copeland A., Gary (1997), Inside Political Campaigns: Theory and Practice, Praeger

5.7 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Correct answers :
 - a) Consistent
 - b) Psychological
 - c) Right
 - d) Positive & Negative
 - e) Leads to waste of resources
- 2) Selective communication helps in choosing content, which endorses the already existing beliefs and likes. It helps in making the selection of content easier. From a communication platform, audience pick and choose only what they want to hear or see while ignoring or not paying much attention to other content. But the negative influence is that the audience will neglect the rest of the content or news which may be of very important or interesting in nature.
- 3) In the business world, silo mentality means departments within an organisation not sharing information with others in the same organisation. In media houses content generators (journalists) also create silos. The tendency is not to discuss the subjects on which they are working. This may lead to duplication of work among the content generators resulting in loss of human resources, efforts, money and time.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) Correct choices are given below:
 - a) Media has limited power to influence people
 - b) Leon Festinger's cognitive dissonance theory
- 2) Cognition is a mental action process to acquire information, knowledge, and understanding. It uses existing knowledge to produce new knowledge. In simple terms, it can be said "information processing". The social cognitive theory of communication explains how humans perform by seeing the performance of others and imitating them. Hence, the mass media messages become the source of observation and learning. Understanding the very concept of cognition and communication has become inevitable for the media to perform better.
- 3) The three theories of selectivity are — Socioemotional Theory, Social Comparison Theory, and Reinforcement Theory.

Check Your Progress 3

1) Correct Match

A	B
a) Attitude is	An internal factor
b) Perception is	Way something is regarded
c) Information processing in mind is like	Computer processing
d) Selective Retention follows	Perception

2) Brief notes:

- a) **Selective Attention:** People are selective or choosy while paying attention to content in the media. The attention is usually for a brief time. In every person, there are self-imposed limitations to pay attention, understand and process all information available. When there is a lot of information, good or bad, people pay attention only to that information what they like.
- b) **Selective Retention:** An individual remembers accurately what s/he likes. The mind cannot remember all the information it is exposed to. People remember properly only that information or images they like, closer to beliefs and values. Though some information which is not close to heart is remembered, it may not remain in the mind for long.
- c) **Selective Recall:** It is similar to attention and retention. People recall words, quotes, incidents and information that suit them. They may remember a whole lot of information but they recall selectively. What is retained in the mind is what is liked by an individual. Hence, the same is recalled.

UNIT 6 INDIVIDUAL DIFFERENCES THEORY

Structure

- 6.0 Introduction
- 6.1 Learning Outcomes
- 6.2 Psychology of Individual Differences
 - 6.2.1 Bullet Theory vs. Individual Differences Theory
 - 6.2.2 Evidences Against Bullet Theory
- 6.3 Nature of Individual Differences Theory of Mass Communication
 - 6.3.1 Learning Theoretical Orientations
 - 6.3.2 Cognitive Dissonance Theory
 - 6.3.3 Uses and Gratifications Approach
- 6.4 Individual Differences in Intelligence and Personality Factors
- 6.5 Selectivity as a Mechanism in Response to Communication Messages
 - 6.5.1 Selective Exposure and Selective Avoidance
 - 6.5.2 Selective Perception
 - 6.5.3 Selective Retention
- 6.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 6.7 Further Readings
- 6.8 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

6.0 INTRODUCTION

You have read in the previous units that communication is a complex process. It involves production, transmission, reception and effects of communication messages. To understand and explain how this process works, several theories of communication have been propounded over the last 100 years. These theories have emerged from different sources as the subject matter is interdisciplinary in nature. Primarily linguistics, social and behavioural sciences have contributed much to these theoretical developments. The contribution of psychology to communication theorising has been enormous (Eswara, 2016). Both cognitive and learning theorists in the field of psychology have offered several explanations facilitating our understanding of communication behaviour. One major contribution of psychology is the Individual Differences Theory of Communication.

In this unit, we will discuss this individual differences theory, outlining its nature, assertions, and explanations. Further, the unit will present empirical evidence on how individual differences operate in the process of producing differential effects.

6.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this unit and working through the exercises, you should be able to:

- discuss the role of individual differences in personal characteristics in the selection, perception, understanding and accepting communication messages;
- compare how this conception is different from the earlier notions of media effects;
- describe different communication theories invoking the role of individual differences in explaining communication behaviour;
- identify certain key cognitive and personality factors critical in communication process;
- analyse the mechanisms of selective exposure and avoidance, selective perception and selective retention operating in the communication process; and
- explain that the media effects are not universal, but individual specific.

6.2 PSYCHOLOGY OF INDIVIDUAL DIFFERENCES

Communication is an act of behaviour. Behaviour can simply be defined as a response to a stimulus. How individuals respond to a given stimulus or a set of stimuli is largely determined by (a) situational factors and (b) personal factors. While situational factors refer to the communication context, the personal factors belong to the individual. The personal factors include the cognitive, emotional and personality characteristics of the individual. To provide the necessary background, let us briefly outline the psychology of individual differences.

Variety is the principle of nature. One of the major tenets of modern psychology is that each individual is unique. Human beings differ greatly from one another in their psychological make-up. These differences are partly due to their inherited biological endowment (heredity), but are largely shaped by their different learning experiences in the social context in which they grow up (environment). During the course of early development, as they are exposed to different learning experiences (socialisation), they acquire a set of attitudes, values, beliefs, personality traits that set them apart from each other. The individual differences theory of mass communication postulates that these differences in psychological organisation of people account for variations in communication behaviours. These personal characteristics and orientations intervene and produce different outcomes in communication situations.

6.2.1 Bullet Theory vs. Individual Differences Theory

The technological developments and the industrial revolution in the West paved the way for the enormous growth of mass media in the 19th century. There was huge concern about the possible effects of media on individual behaviours and social and political systems. The role played by American newspapers in winning support for the Spanish-American war, the influence of Madison Avenue campaigns on consumers and the success of Nazi propaganda during World War II – these historical events prompted media analysts to advance a theory about the powerful media effects. And this theory is variously referred to as the **magic bullet theory** or the **hypodermic needle model** or the **stimulus-response theory** of mass communication.

It will be useful to recall the assumptions of bullet theory which include:

- a) Media messages (like 'magic bullets') flow *directly* to the receivers;
- b) Media receivers are amorphous in nature, and they are *passive* and *defenseless*;
- c) Media messages reach every audience member the same way and produce *uniform effects*;
- d) Media receivers are just '*atoms*' (anonymous and isolated individuals) and are not influenced by the groups to which they belong;
- e) In sum, media have *direct, immediate* and *powerful* effect on the receivers.

6.2.2 Evidences against Bullet Theory

However, the above conception of mass communication was attacked by several sources and was flooded with research evidence casting doubts about the assumptions and claims of magic bullet theory.

The initial evidence questioning the bullet theory came from the very same media event which is often considered as a classic example in support for this theory. The event was a radio version of H.G. Wells' "War of the Worlds." On October 30, 1938, the eve of Halloween day, Mercury Theater broadcast this play and the audience heard that Martians had invaded the earth in Grover's Mill, New Jersey.

About 12 million people in U S listened to this programme, and of those about a million actually believed that Martians had invaded the earth. There was a kind of mass hysteria following the broadcast leading to chaos and panic all around nation. A careful analysis of this archetypal incident supporting the bullet theory paradoxically provides some evidence questioning its very assumptions. A group of social scientists (Cantril, 1940) who studied this panic broadcast programme found that by no means all those who listened to the programme believed it was news. Further, not all of them reacted in the same way to broadcast message. There were individual differences in their reactions based on education level of listeners, their critical ability, their strength of religious beliefs, and other personality factors like emotional insecurity, phobic personality, lack of self-confidence, and fatalism.

Additional evidences against the bullet theory came from different sources. The Yale Communication Research Programme under the leadership of Hovland (Hovland, Janis & Kelley, 1953; Hovland and Janis, 1959; Sherif & Hovland, 1961) working within the framework of learning theories emphasised the role of predispositional and mediating factors in the communication process. Others like McGuire (1968) and Berlo (1960) also highlighted the importance of personal factors in producing communication effects. The Columbia sociologists (Lazarsfeld, Berleson and Gaudet, 1948) in their survey studies of voters, found the importance of selection and perception of media messages campaign impacts. Another line of opposition to bullet notion came from Uses and Gratification theorists who focused on the role of individual needs in the selection and consumption of media content. Further, cognitive consistency theorists (see Cohen, 1964), notably Festinger (1957) postulated dissonance as a psychological state determining media orientation. All these and others recognise that the use and effect of communication are individual specific, and the individual differences

are factors worthy of consideration in the communication process. These viewpoints will be discussed in some detail in the coming sections of this unit.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: a) Use the space below to write your answers.

b) Compare with answers provided at the end of the unit.

- 1) What are the main causes for differences in psychological make-up of people?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

- 2) List out the major assumptions of bullet theory of mass communication.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

- 3) Specify the important sources of evidences against the bullet theory.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

6.3 NATURE OF INDIVIDUAL DIFFERENCES THEORY OF MASS COMMUNICATION

At the outset, it is perhaps fair to admit that a formal theory of individual differences of mass communication has never been formulated. However, it is equally true that various media studies have suggested the psychological mechanisms and the personality make-up of the individuals play a vital role in mediating the communication effects. As De Fleur (1966) has very succinctly stated:

“From a multiplicity of available content, the members of the audience selectively attend to messages, particularly if they were related to their interest, consistent with his attitudes, congruent with his beliefs, and supportive of his values. His response to such messages was modified by his psychological make-up” (p. 122). De Fleur proceeds to label this conception, ‘**Individual Differences Theory of Mass Communication.**’

What is implicit in the above statement is that the reception and response to media messages are not automatic as was presumed by the bullet theory. On the other hand, the interests, attitudes, beliefs, values and needs intervene between the stimulus (the media messages) and the response (in the form of selection, perception, acceptance and action) of the audience members. So, the individual differences in these psychological characteristics cause differential reactions from audience members to the same media messages.

Given the above logic, De Fleur maintains that the original S-R relationship becomes rather complex. This relationship undergoes modification due to the interaction between message attributes and personality characteristics of the audience members. Since individual differences among members are a natural phenomenon, De Fleur proposes variations in effect corresponding to such individual differences. Guided by this reasoning, he revises the old mechanistic S-R formula to accommodate the individual differences as “Cause-(intervening process)-effect.” This intervening process may be considered the core of Individual Differences Theory of mass media.

In the following sections of this Unit, we will outline how these intervening processes operate, and the various mechanisms of this operation. It must be kept in mind, however, there is no single individual differences theory of mass communication as such. But the role of individual differences – in abilities, attitudes, beliefs, values, motives and other personality orientations — are considered by different theories explaining communication behaviours.

6.3.1 Learning Theoretical Orientations

Consider the De Fleur formula of communication process cited in the previous section. It simply conceives communication process as, “cause - (intervening process) - effect.” Perhaps one of the early models falling within the framework, but preceding it is Hovland’s theoretical model of persuasive communication emerging out of the Yale communication research (Hovland, Janis & Kelley, 1953; Hovland and Janis, 1959). The basic communication model proposed by Hovland and his coworkers conceived communication situation in terms of message structure and content, source characteristics, type of channel, and setting. In addition, situational elements that determine what audience members attend to and how besides the attention, comprehension, and acceptance factors operate to produce observable communication effects like changes in opinion, perception, affect, and action.

Hovland’s conception of communication process and effects argues that the receivers of communication messages are viewed as learners of information provided in the message. And through attention and comprehension of message content, they are assumed to be learning and accepting the messages following the learning principles.

So the main contention of Hovland thesis is that individual differences in these predispositional and mediating factors account for variations in communication effects.

Recognising the importance of personal factors in persuasive communication, Hovland and his colleagues found two types of personality factors affecting responses to communication messages: (1) intellectual abilities, and (2) motivational factors. Particularly, the researchers found relationship between intelligence and persuasion. People with high intelligence are logical and capable of drawing valid inferences. This makes it easy to persuade them if the message is factual, relevant and logical. At the same time, people with high intelligence are more critical of the arguments, and therefore, are difficult to persuade if the messages are false, illogical or irrelevant.

Another finding of the Yale group is that individual differences in personality organisation are also related to susceptibility to persuasion. They have found the high persuasibility is associated with low self-esteem, feelings of social inadequacy, inhibition of aggression and depression. Arthur Cohen (1964) has listed some of the personality factors affecting persuasibility. The list includes such factors as: perceptual dependence meaning those who rely in their perceptions more on external cues, authoritarianism, other-directedness, social isolation and richness in fantasy.

Yet another contribution of Yale researchers is the Social Judgment Theory (Sherif & Hovland, 1961). The social judgment theory takes into account the initial attitudinal positions of the recipients of the message in accepting or rejecting it. This theory assumes that people have categories of positions on a given issue. These positions are

- a) acceptable / the *latitude of acceptances*
- b) unacceptable / the *latitude of rejection*
- c) neutral / the *latitude of non-commitment*

The individual's most favoured position in the *latitude of acceptance* is called the *anchor point*. Further, Sherif and his colleagues indicate that the level of personal involvement in the issue, called the *ego-involvement*, affects the size of these latitudes. Higher the ego-involvement in the issue leads to larger *latitude of rejection*. If the position advocated by the message falls within the latitude of acceptance, and if it is closer to the anchor point, then there is a tendency to perceive it as close to his position than its actual position. This process is called **assimilation**. On the other hand, if the position of the message is away from the recipient's position, then it will be perceived farther away than its actual position. This is called **contrast**. These judgmental processes of assimilation or contrast affect the acceptance or rejection of communication messages. Thus, the social judgment theory clearly points out that the individual differences in initial positions of the audience members and their distance from the position of the advocated message are a crucial factor in producing communication effects.

William McGuire (1968), for example, proposes a two-factor model of persuasion. In this model, there are two basic steps involved:

- a) Reception of the message content; and

b) Yielding to what is comprehended

On the basis of this model, McGuire predicts that opinion change depends on effective reception of the message and yielding to the contents of the message. McGuire elaborated the persuasion process by identifying six steps:

- Presentation
- Attention
- Reception
- Comprehension
- Yielding
- Retention
- and Behaviour.

Further, McGuire hypothesised relationship between ability and motivational factors, on the one hand, and aspects of reception of the messages, on the other. One or two examples of these possible relationships may be cited here. People with high intelligence possess cognitive skills which facilitate better comprehension of messages, but may be less yielding because of the critical skills. Thus, McGuire uses this model to explain the effects of various individual difference factors in explaining differences in susceptibility of persuasion.

Berlo's (1960) S-M-C-R (source-message-channel-receiver) model also recognises the importance of individual differences in communication process. Berlo proposes the following key factors in the production and consumption of messages in a communication process;

- Skills
- Attitudes
- Knowledge
- Social system and
- Culture of both the source and the receiver

The role of individual factors is highlighted in Petty and Cacioppo (1966) theory of persuasion, called the Elaboration Likelihood Model. The theory outlines two basic routes to persuasion;

- 1) One route is based on thoughtful consideration of arguments central to the issue.
- 2) The other route is based on the affective associations.

When people face persuasive messages, they indulge in high or low elaboration. Elaboration here refers to the level of effort invested by the recipients of the messages. The level of elaboration determines the choice of their route. Those who express high elaboration take the central route processing and those with low elaboration opt for the peripheral route processing. In the central route, the contents of message are closely examined; whereas in the peripheral route, the receivers are influenced by other considerations than the message content for e.g., the credibility of the source or his attractiveness. Further, in central route, the effect like attitude reinforcement or change is based on strength of arguments

and their relevance to the issue; but in the peripheral route, the effect is determined by other considerations in the communication context. Finally, the effect is more enduring if one processes through central route, and it is less enduring and subject to counter attacks if one follows the peripheral route.

The two most influential factors in elaboration are: motivation and ability. Motivation refers to the desire to evaluate the message, and ability is the capability of the individual for critical evaluation. In the final analysis, it is the motivational and ability factors leading to the choice of information processing routes, and the chosen route ultimately determining the effect.

6.3.2 Cognitive Dissonance Theory

The Cognitive Dissonance Theory of Leon Festinger (1957) has been widely used in explaining persuasive communication studies. The theory proposes that when individuals are involved in conflicting situations between their attitudes, beliefs and behaviours, they experience a feeling of discomfort. And this state of discomfort is called cognitive dissonance. This can be illustrated with a common example. When a smoker comes to know that smoking causes cancer, s/he undergoes this feeling of discomfort. Smoking is a behavioural act and knowing that it causes cancer is cognition. There is inconsistency between behaviour and cognition here producing dissonance. This dissonance, according to Festinger, is a noxious state, and the individual experiencing it strives to get out of it. There are several ways to resolve this situation. In this example, the smoker may choose to quit smoking or s/he may seek information that denies the relationship to cancer.

In the context of cognitive dissonance theory, individual differences come to play in ways people resolve their inconsistencies in attitudes and behaviours. Some people have the capacity to cope up with the situation and not experiencing the tension. But those who attempt to reduce them employ variety of strategies. In matters of media, they vary in the extent of media use and the selection and perception of media content. Selective exposure and selective avoidance to communication messages is one of favoured modes used in the resolution of dissonance.

6.3.3 Uses and Gratification Approach

Another theoretical formulation which recognises the role of individual differences in media influence is the Uses and Gratification Theory, for short, UGT (Katz et al, 1974), discussed in detail in Unit 3. This theory primarily focuses on individual needs in the selection and consumption of media content. Uses and Gratification Theory seeks to explain why people seek out the media and for what purposes they use them. UGT questions the core notion of passive audience of Bullet Theory and presumes that individuals have power over the selection and usage of media. They respond in different ways to mass media based on their psychological requirements and people consume the mass media to fulfill those requirements. Research studies in the context of UGT suggest that individuals deliberately seek out media to fulfill their personal needs such as entertainment, relaxation, or socialising. Needs that affect media usage are grouped into four major categories: (a) information needs, (b) integrative needs (sense of belongingness), (3) affective needs, and (4) escapist needs.

6.4 INDIVIDUAL DIFFERENCES IN INTELLIGENCE AND PERSONALITY FACTORS

In the previous section, we have seen how some theorists, particularly Yale researchers, have conceptualised the role of individual differences among media audience as factors affecting the nature of communication effects. In this section, we will summarise some of the correlates of susceptibility to media influence, such as gender, age, self esteem etc.

Gender: Early research tended to show that women are more susceptible to persuasion than men (e.g., Janis & Field, 1959). This difference was explained in terms of cultural demands expecting greater conformity from women (Hovland & Janis, 1959). McGuire (1959) attempted to explain these differences in terms of presumed message reception skills of women. There are a variety of findings on gender differences in reception to communication messages, but it is still agreed that small gender differences exist.

Age: Studies investigating the relationship between age and susceptibility to influence are consistent in showing that young children are more vulnerable to suggestions than adults. There is also some evidence suggesting a curvilinear relationship indicating that both younger and older people being more persuasive than the middle age groups.

Self-esteem: Janis was one of the early researchers in this area. He proposed, what he called a “self-esteem hypothesis,” which predicts that persons with low self-esteem are likely to be high on persuasibility. Studies by Janis & Field, Janis and Rife support the above hypothesis showing an inverse relationship between self-esteem and persuasibility.

Cognitive Needs and Cognitive Style: Cognitive need refers to a desire for clarity or meaning about one’s experiences about the world around them. There are differences among people; some have a high need for cognitive clarity and others a low need for cognitive clarity. People also vary in terms of their characteristic cognitive styles. Cognitive style refers to the way people perceive, remember and think about the world around them. Some pay little attention for details, while others look for details.

In brief, it may be summarised here that age, gender, self-esteem and other individual differences have been studied as factors in persuasion effects by a host of researchers. The results of different investigators are often inconsistent. Further, the receiver factors seem to interact with other factors in the process (such as source characteristics, message characteristics, and so on). Thus, the relationship between receiver characteristics and susceptibility to communication messages is rather complex and conflicting. Nevertheless, individual differences in receiver characteristics affect communication process is an accepted principle.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: a) Use the space below to write your answers, and

b) Compare with answers provided at the end of the unit.

- 1) According to Yale researchers, what are the determining factors of communication effects?

-
-
-
- 2) What are some of the personal factors that correlate with persuasibility?
-
-
-
- 3) List major communication theories which invoke individual differences in explaining communication effects.
-
-
-

6.5 SELECTIVITY AS A MECHANISM IN RESPONSE TO COMMUNICATION MESSAGES

The amount of communication input in a given individuals' everyday life is enormous. Particularly in this age of mass media, we encounter messages from different sources all the time. It is practically impossible to respond to all these messages. Then, the basic question is how individuals select from this plethora of messages available to them, how they perceive them, how much they retain, and how they respond to them. What factors determine these selections, perceptions and responses? It is here that individual differences come to play, and the factors like intellectual abilities, attitudes, beliefs, motivations, and personality orientations of individual users influence the course of action at each level.

In the following section of this unit, we will discuss in detail the operation of some of these processes and the research evidences bearing on them.

6.5.1 Selective Exposure and Selective Avoidance

As you have read in Unit 5, selective exposure to stimuli is one of the basic notions in psychology. It has been widely accepted as a factor in causing communication effects. Different communication theories have invoked this mechanism to explain the success or failure of communication messages in producing their intended effects. In this Unit, we will briefly summarise some of the classical view points and the evidences in support of them to link with the Individual Difference Theory.

The classic example of the operation of selective exposure principle was a study by Lazarsfeld, Berleson and Gaudet (1948). They were studying the use of election campaign materials by voters. They found that from the abundant campaign material available the voters selected that suited their own biases. In other words,

the voters chose material which supported their pre-existed party preferences. And this has been used as an explanation for why political campaigns reinforce pre-existing preferences and predispositions.

Klapper (1960) also discusses the role of selective exposure in his book on the effects of mass communication. He believes that mass communication just reinforces people's predispositions. Klapper suggests that people selectively expose themselves to media messages which are consonant with their beliefs, attitudes and values. Then they perceive the selected material influenced by their own predispositions. Two individuals may view the same message in different ways and react differently. Even the retention of learned material from the media is selective guided by one's needs, wants and other personal factors.

Festinger's cognitive dissonance theory which has generated a whole range of research in persuasive communication and attitude change invokes selective exposure. Cognitive dissonance, according to Festinger (1957) exists when an individual faces two cognitions, which are conflicting to one another. We can illustrate this with the help of a decision making situation. The decision maker is always confronted with the negative aspects (dissonant cognitions) of the chosen alternative and the positive aspects (consonant cognitions) of the rejected alternative.

One of the favoured strategies in dissonance reduction mechanism is seeking information bolstering supportive cognitions and avoiding information contributing dissonant cognitions. Actually, the individual may resort to both of them. A good example is the reading of car advertisements by new car owners. It has been found that the new car owners tend to prefer reading advertisements of their own brand over advertisements of the competing brands. This bias in preference for consonant information is also found in the evaluation of such information. Studies have shown that messages supportive of their own decisions are considered more credible and reliable than those which go against one's decisions. This has been shown in the behaviours of smokers who usually undermine the validity of reports claiming that smoking causes cancer. Feather (1963) found that among smokers, information denying relationship between smoking and cancer was preferred to information confirming such linkage.

6.5.2 Selective Perception

Selective perception, as discussed in the previous unit, refers to biases in the way we see things. Our perceptions are often guided by our expectations. We see what we expect to see and not necessarily what is actually there. It is a common saying that we see things as we are and not as they are. In the context of communication, selective perception is the operation of receivers' pre-existing beliefs, attitudes and value orientations affecting the meanings of communication messages.

Some archetypal studies in selective perception relevant to communication are available. One of them is a classic study by Hastorf and Cantril (1954) called "They saw the Game". The study dealt with the varying perceptions of spectators of a football game between Princeton and Dartmouth. In the game there were several unfair means. However, it was found that the perception of who played the dirty game was determined largely by spectators' attitudinal predispositions. Princeton students thought that Dartmouth team made more violations and was less fair, and Dartmouth students found it the other way.

In another study, Cooper and Jahoda (1947) investigated the perceptions of prejudiced and non-prejudiced readers of a prejudiced cartoon character named Mr. Biggott. They found that the prejudiced readers distorted the meaning of the underlying message of the cartoon. Yet another study by Vidmar and Rokeach (1974) investigated the reactions of viewers of a TV show called 'All in the family.' The main character in the show, Archie Bunker, is depicted as a 'lovable bigot.' It was found that both low-prejudiced and high-prejudiced group of viewers liked the character Archie, but for different reasons. Low prejudiced viewers considered the programme a satire, but the high-prejudiced ones viewed it as an honest portrayal.

All the above studies suggest that how one perceives and interprets media messages that are affected by the pre-existing attitudes and beliefs about the issues. Thus, the process of selective perception is crucial in determining media effects. As our perceptions are guided by our own images, it is possible that that the messages only reinforce what we believe than changing our held beliefs.

6.5.3 Selective Retention

Selective retention of the material is yet another mediating factor limiting the effects of media. Selective retention refers to the tendency to remember media content consistent with ones existing attitudes and beliefs. Both learning theorists and consistency theorists assume material having unpleasant consequences will be forgotten more quickly than those which may bring pleasant outcomes.

To sum up, communication effects do not take place in isolation. The thesis of individual differences theory is that several factors come to play in the process influencing the communication outcomes. The demographic categories to which people belong (e.g., sex, age, educational level, etc.), the personal characteristics (e.g., intelligence, personality traits, attitudes, values, etc) and the social relationships (e.g., group affiliations) – all these factors affect the way audience members react to communication messages.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: a) Use the space below to write your answers, and (b) Compare with answers provided at the end of the unit.

- 1) Explain selectivity as a mechanism in communication process.

.....

.....

.....

- 2) What is the explanation of cognitive dissonance theory for selectivity of media content?

.....

.....

.....

.....

- 3) List some classic studies in selective perception. What do these studies reveal?

.....

.....

.....

6.6 LET US SUM UP

The technological developments and the industrial revolution during the 19th century brought about major changes in the society and living conditions of the people. The growth of urban centers, affluence, leisure, feelings of alienation among people provided the right environment for the growth of newspapers and later other media. People became concerned about the power of these media, and the role of media in the early part of 20th century in public affairs and marketing led to believe that media is all powerful. The bullet theory of mass media conceptualised a powerful media and a passive audience, and the media messages going directly to the isolated, “atomistic” audience members creating uniform powerful effects on them. However, this notion was challenged from many sources, and prominent among them is the Individual Differences theory of media effects.

Individual differences in human abilities and personality is a basic law of psychology. And as applied to communication, it proposes that there are variations in responses to communication stimuli among audience members because of their abilities, attitudes, beliefs, values and personality organisation. This notion of individual differences is invoked by different communication theoretical orientations. These theorists emphasise individual differences in these mediating and predispositional factors as crucial variables in communication process.

The uses and gratifications theory and the cognitive consistency theories also invoke individual differences in explaining what the individuals seek and how they use the media. The most important processes involved are the mechanisms of selective exposure and avoidance of media messages, selective perception of them and selective retention.

6.7 FURTHER READINGS

Berlo, D. K. (1960), *The Process of Communication*. New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston.

Cooper, E., and M. Jahoda (1947), The evasion of propaganda. *The Journal of Psychology*, 23, 15-25.

De Fleur, M. L (1966), *Theories of Mass Communication*. David McKay Co., Inc.

6.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Individual differences are mainly caused by two sets of factors: (a) heredity: the inherited biological endowment, and (b) environment: the learning experiences in the social context while growing up.
- 2) The major assumptions of Bullet Theory are- messages flow directly from media to audience members; audiences are isolated individuals, passive and defenseless; the media effect is both uniform and powerful.
- 3) Main evidences against Bullet Theory come from: the Invasion from Mars study by Cantril; the voter surveys of Columbia sociologists; the findings of Yale communication researchers; from the evidences supporting Uses and Gratifications theories and Cognitive dissonance theory.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) According to Yale researchers, two sets of factors are considered important in moderating communication effects: (a) the predispositional factors and (b) the mediating factors: attention, comprehension and retention.
- 2) A number of factors have found to be related to susceptibility to persuasive messages. They include: gender, age, intelligence, self-esteem, cognitive needs and styles, etc.
- 3) Many theories take into account individual differences among audience members as causes for variation in communication effects. Prominent among them are: (a) Learning theories, (b) Cognitive Dissonance, (c) Uses and Gratifications, and (d) Elaboration Likelihood Model.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) People tend to select, interpret and remember media content determined by their biases: pre-existing preferences and predispositions. These biases are the result of one's own initial attitudes toward the issue and the ego-involvement in it; the attitudes, beliefs, values, personality orientations, the norms of groups to which they belong.
- 2) Cognitive dissonance theory assumes induction of a state of dissonance when there is inconsistency in cognitions and behaviours; this is a noxious state and induces (drive) the person to reduce. As a mechanism of dissonance reduction individuals tend to be selective in their media use.
- 3) Classical studies in the area of selective perception include those by Hastorf and Cantril; Cooper and Jahoda; and Vidmar and Rokeach. All these studies suggest that people tend to perceive media messages guided by their own pre-existing attitudes, beliefs and values.

UNIT 7 PERSUASION AND ATTITUDE

Structure

- 7.0 Introduction
- 7.1 Learning Outcomes
- 7.2 Attitudes
 - 7.2.1 Classical Conditioning
 - 7.2.2 Attitude Change
 - 7.2.3 Cognitive Dissonance
 - 7.2.4 Strengths and Limitations
- 7.3 Fear Appeals
 - 7.3.1 Perceived Fear
 - 7.3.2 Hidden Persuasion
 - 7.3.3 Media of Persuasion
- 7.4 Persuasive Advertising
 - 7.4.1 Strategic Communication
 - 7.4.2 Persuasion for Social Change
- 7.5 Let Us Sum Up
- 7.6 Further Readings
- 7.7 Key Terms
- 7.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

7.0 INTRODUCTION

The arrival of mass media on the horizon created both enthusiasm and fear in the minds of media scholars and other academicians alike. John Dewey, American Psychologist who is known for his contribution to social reform has been considered as a pioneer among communication theorists in the United States. Dewey believed that in the industrialised urban environment, mass media could be used to promote the social contexts of the past and create a new form of community feeling. As a social and educational reformer, Dewey's tilt was towards community-orientation, as he believed that a free system of mass media would disseminate scientific social knowledge to masses. Walter Lippmann, American Journalist and author of classic book, *Public Opinion*, expressed his serious concerns about the mass media influence.

You have read in the previous unit that during the World War I and II, the United States, Britain, and Germany used media like newspapers, radio, posters, and newsreels as tools of propaganda to manage and influence public opinion. Propaganda posters of World War I in Britain were famous for persuading young men to join the army to defend the country in a society of social inequality. Media was the potential source of information during World Wars to instill patriotism and win public support for the war in Europe. After the war, there was renewed interest in using media for propaganda. According to Roger Brown (Words and Things, 1958, New York the Free Press, P258), American social psychologist, who has worked on techniques of persuasion through language says, that Propaganda takes place when 'the action which is the goal of the

persuasive effort will be advantageous to the persuader but not in the best interests of the persuader'. Harold Dwight Lasswell, American social scientist propounded the theory of Propaganda and helped us understand the effects of propaganda on the audience.

All of us can remember the Nazi propaganda of Paul Joseph Goebbels, German propagandist who served as Minister of Propaganda of Nazi Germany under Adolf Hitler. Persuasion has many shades of activities, some good, and others, bad. Today most media content aims to persuade the consumers. Of course, advertisements and public relations aim to persuade publics for favourable response. The main objective of media is to reach out to target audience. By nature, audience resists persuasive messages. For example, experts doubt whether advertisers have been able to persuade people and market their ideas, as advertisement is an investment. It is likely that the power of advertisements to influence people is also exaggerated. Research suggests that persuasive messages have only modest effects.

William James McGuire considered as the father of 'social cognition' and known for his scholarly works on 'attitude change' and the 'self-concept', has helped us understand the nuances of persuasion. A scholar on psychology of persuasion, McGuire has developed a scientific and systematic linear model of persuasion. It provides a clear frame to evaluate particular theories and hypotheses. In verbal communication, McGuire listed five types of independent variables such as characteristics of the source, message, channel, receiver, and destination. Source characteristics include the credibility of the communicator. Message element includes use of fear appeals and different types of misleading arguments. Channel variable cover whether the message is presented live or via TV or newspapers. Audience characteristics are receivers' personality characteristics and prior opinions concerning a subject. The destination variables are the target of a message and factors that may lead people to resist persuasion.

McGuire has also identified six types of dependent variables in a linear fashion. A message is given and the receiver gets it. S/he understands it, yields to it. Either attitude formation or change takes place, retains the changed attitude, and finally acts according to it. The process consisting of presentation, attention, comprehension, yielding, retention, and overt behaviour is sequential. However, persuasion will not always follow this path. Sometimes, individuals may accept or yield to the message even before they understand it. This model of persuasion has simplified the process. This unit focuses on two important facets of mass communication, persuasion, and attitude change.

7.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- discuss the role of media in attitudinal change;
- describe different perspectives of persuasion;
- analyse whether persuasive messages can bring desired change; and
- assess the media influence on cognitive abilities of the audience.

7.2 ATTITUDES

People have attitudes. Attitude and behaviour are interrelated. Attitude is presumed to indicate how a person thinks or feels and is concerned with how a person's mind works. Behaviour is an individual's response or expression of one's feelings to the environment. Immediacy is its characteristic. Traditionally, attitudes are considered as intervening variables between communication and behaviour. Communication influences attitudes, which in turn will influence the behaviour. Attitude has been defined as "responses that locate objects of thought on dimensions of judgment" (McGuire, 1986). It is a "summary evaluation of an object" and therefore is a cognitive element. You will know one's attitude through one's behaviour. It is a generalised intention to behave in a certain manner towards an object. It refers to the individuals behavioural intentions. The three elements of a message effects are:

- 1) A person becomes aware of an object and its characteristics.
- 2) After a while s/he changes or forms an attitude based on his new impressions.
- 3) Lastly, s/he forms or alters changes his/her behavioural intentions.

These three elements mentioned are interrelated. They influence each other in a reciprocal fashion. Attitudes are both verbal and non-verbal. Body language speaks about the mental state of mind of a person about an issue or a person or an event. A sticker promoting 'drive safe' or 'organ donation' can make one feel good or bad about an issue. For example, how public reacts to the victims of a road accident reveals about their attitude. Attitude is compared to other related concepts. For instance, an opinion is an expression of attitude but narrower than attitude. An attitude may be a person's general feelings about an issue. Emotions are the affective elements of an attitude. These may refer to the highly transitory human reactions. Attitudes are often considered to have an element of stability to them, although some scholars consider this difference as relative. Again, it is pointed out that verbal communication is one of the major sources of attitude formation and change among human beings. At the same time, we cannot ignore the influence of non-verbal communication and direct experiences with an object, which are likely to affect human attitudes. For example, young people touching elder's feet as a mark of respect and culture has gained social acceptance that indicates one's attitude towards one's culture and values.

7.2.1 Classical Conditioning

According to one kind of learning theory, persuasion is part of knowledge acquisition. Most of these theories are based on behaviourism but they ignore or give less importance to yielding. A well-known learning theory is the classical conditioning. The elements of classical conditioning are:

- 1) Unconditioned stimulus.
- 2) Unconditioned response, and
- 3) Conditioned stimulus

Unconditioned Stimulus is a reaction that is expressed naturally to a situation like for instance experts have cited the example of smell of your favourite food which makes you feel hungry. In this instance, smell of food is the **Unconditioned Stimulus**. The **Unconditioned Response** is the smell of food that triggered natural

response. The famous example is the experiment conducted by Russian physiologist Ivan Pavlov. The experiment involved a dog provided with meat powder. There was biological instinct of dog salivating at the sight of meat powder. Pavlov rang a bell to signal the availability of meat powder, which conditioned the dog to salivate. The sound of the bell is the **Conditioned Stimulus** as it is paired with the food. Many media commercial messages of the day use the principles of classical conditioning in them. Classical Conditioning theory is about learning a new behaviour. This concept is used in Marketing Communication which aims to build relationship between customers and the product.

Operant or Instrumental Conditioning is a learning theory based on the use of rewards and punishment as the learning means. Psychologist B.F. Skinner explains Operant Conditioning as a method of learning through rewards and punishment, where a person makes an association between a particular behavior and a consequence (Skinner, 1938). One type of response may end up in punishment and another may result in reward. Punishment makes the response not to occur in future while reward encourages people to respond in the same fashion in future also. Human tendency is to repeat the same behavior that has resulted in favourable consequences and avoid the behavior that has resulted in unpleasant events. These learning theories focus on environmental stimuli because of the premise that human behaviour is affected by external factors.

Both Classical and Operant Conditioning have been adopted in Advertising as both these theories help understand the process involved to change consumer behaviour.

McGuire says that information processing theories take a wider view of the persuasion process. They consider individuals as rational, 'linear processors of incoming stimuli'. Their perspective does not take into account the ego issues and irrational ways of attitude. The functional theories evaluated motivations of people for their attitudes, along with much needed and supplementary perspectives. These theories consider individuals as highly irrational. D Katz identified functions of Attitude:

- 1) Adjustment or utilitarian function.
- 2) Ego-defensive function which Freudians call as defence mechanisms.
- 3) Attitudes 'may serve' the Value Expressive function.
- 4) A few Attitudes serve as Knowledge Function.

The study of functions of attitudes has a **Utilitarian application** for persuasive communication. For example, the attitude of workers to their management depends on work environment. If it is favourable, workers adjust to the needs and demands of the work place and develop favourable attitude towards the organisation. Strikes, protest behaviour illustrates negative attitude of workers. The cognitive dissonance theory of Leon Festinger and the Balance theory of Heider view that people adjust their attitudes and behaviours to accommodate phenomena like self-interest, communication, and pressure from other people.

Ego-Defensive function means an individual uses defense mechanisms to protect his/her self-esteem despite wrong doing to gain psychological satisfaction of justifying the action. It is common to find such instance in organisations where a

subordinate worker challenges a boss and the boss becomes defensive to protect his ego by denial. It is all about how people respond to issues that affect their self esteem.

Value- Expressive Function of attitudes reflects a person's core values. A person may take pride being affiliated to particular ideology.

Knowledge function of attitude refers to our need to seek knowledge or understanding of an issue. We may not need to understand every new subject. Attitudes help us to give selective attention to new objects.

7.2.2 Attitude Change

A systematic study of attitude change and persuasion began in the first half of the twentieth century. The World War II offered an opportunity to study the topic of attitude change and the role of media in it. The war was also a propaganda war. The Nazis and their allies had their own propaganda machinery working to spread lies. Thus, the war provided scope for research in attitude change. Researchers wanted to find out the psychological barriers to persuasion and attitude change.

The US had The Information and Education Division with an Experimental Section. Carl Hovland managed this group. Initially, the section produced documentaries and orientation movies series called *Why We Fight*. These were produced under the supervision of well-known Hollywood director Frank Capra. As a psychologist, Hovland had a background in behaviourism and learning theory. He employed the concept of controlled variation to examine the influence of media content elements on human attitudes. Hovland and his cohorts found out that military propaganda was not all that powerful as imagined earlier. The films could produce very little change in the attitude of soldiers. Time was major factor in attitude change. It meant that shift in attitude was slow and time consuming. Hovland's experiments showed that one side messages were more effective with those who already had a favourable tilt towards the message. On the other, two side presentations were more effective on the people having different perspectives of the issue.

The conclusion was that attitude change was a complex phenomenon. An important principle of attitude change theory is cognitive consistency. From Lazarsfeld to Joseph Klapper, theories suggested that people search for media messages that are consistent with their values and beliefs. In other words, people want to safeguard their existing views by avoiding messages which are contrary in nature.

7.2.3 Cognitive Dissonance

Leon Festinger's theory of cognitive dissonance has generated a lot of interest among media researchers. According to Festinger, information not consistent with a person's values and beliefs, already held by him, will produce a psychological discomfort or dissonance and it must be removed. For instance, when we watch TV news we find it difficult to accept negative news about a political leader whom you support and your mind disagree strongly with the news. It produces feeling of discomfort and that is cognitive dissonance. Festinger says that 'we have an inner drive to hold all our attitudes and behaviour in harmony and avoid disharmony (or dissonance) (Festinger 1957).

In order to reduce disharmony or dissonance you have to change your attitude and behaviour. One way is to rationalise in your mind about why you support a particular political leader or the other way is to change your attitude and belief by acquiring new information about the political leader and establish harmony and thereby reduce dissonance. The person tells for himself and convinces his mind that his belief is not consistent with what majority of them think about the political leader. That is an attitude change. These defense mechanisms are called selective processes. These selective processes are complex and high filtering mechanisms. Attitude change researchers have identified three forms of selectivity: selective exposure, selective retention, and selective perception which you have read in Unit 5.

7.2.4 Strengths and Limitations

Some strengths of the attitude change theory are:

- 1) It focuses on the process that would consider what messages can and cannot have effects on the audience.
- 2) It provides knowledge of influence of individual differences and group membership in shaping media influence.
- 3) Awareness of selectivity process helps in understanding how individuals process the information they get.

Some limitations of the theory are:

- 1) Experimental manipulation is likely to underestimate the power of media.
- 2) It does not concentrate information in modern symbolic media.
- 3) The theory focuses on attitude change only and neglects reinforcement and more complex forms of media influence.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

- 1) Distinguish between attitude and behaviour.

.....

.....

.....

.....

- 2) Explain the linear model of persuasion.

.....

.....

.....

.....

3) Describe the experiment of Carl Hovland.

.....

.....

.....

.....

4) What is cognitive dissonance?

.....

.....

.....

7.3 FEAR APPEALS

Fear appeal is a kind of message intended to persuade people using fear as the one of the emotions to change attitude and behaviour. It is common to find people fear God but religious heads take advantage and use fear as a weapon to gain acceptance. Fear appeals are commonly used in mass media. Advertisements on smoking causes cancer, fear of drunken driving and fear of fatal accidents to illustrate the significance of helmet are other examples extensively used in mass media messages. All food advertisements use fear appeal and not appetite appeal to market food products focusing majorly on heart diseases and health of breadwinner of the family who is responsible for the economic wellbeing of the family.

Fear persuades people to change attitude and learn new behaviour. There are low fear appeals, moderate fear appeals and high fear appeals. Messages with fear appeal are direct and have clarity and credibility. Fear appeal centered political campaigns instill high fear among people, for instance against a political leader who is shown to cause more harm to a particular community or caste or religion. Fear appeal used in education is a trational strategy to instill fears among students to motivate them to enhance their performance and always have good intention unlike politics or commercial advertisements, which aims to sell food products and resort to exaggeration and manipulate facts.

7.3.1 Perceived Fear

Studies related to fear appeals reveal increase in perceived fear among people. They also say that manipulations of fear may not yield the expected results. In other words, increased fear may result in message-consistent attitude to a limited extent. It may also increase the behavioural obedience to a small extent. According to evidence, low fear appeals are found to be more effective with highly anxious people. On the other, high fear appeals are highly effective except with the very anxious people.

Fear appeals have three components:

- 1) The degree of harm of the event
- 2) The possibility of the event happening

3) The odds that available response may prevent the problem

The three elements of any construct are fear, threat, and efficacy. Fear is a negative emotion with a high level of arousal. Threat is an external stimulus variable. Efficacy means belief about one's response to avert threat. Fear occurs when threat is perceived as either high or moderate. Fear may indirectly affect the adaptive and danger control processes. Many advertisements use deceptive communication as part of persuasion process. Many of such exaggerated or deceptive claims may not stand the test of law but the enforcement of regulation is always inefficient. It is difficult to train people to avoid such advertisements.

7.3.2 Hidden Persuasion

Often communication experts refuse to accept that advertisers manipulate the audience through subliminal advertising where a message is perceived unconsciously. It is strong technique used by advertisers and propagandists in politics to persuade the people. However, the idea of subliminal persuasion has been in existence for decades. It was popularised by Vance Packard in a book, *The Hidden Persuaders* as early as 1957. Even advertisements are nicknamed as 'hidden persuaders' for its potential to insert hidden command which is not perceived consciously. However, we understand that subliminal effects have a limited power in a laboratory environment. For instance, subliminal effects may produce desired result by repeated exposure to an advertisement or TV promo of a programme which may persuade the audience show favourable attitude. Here a message is deliberately designed to engage audience subconsciously to change one's attitude and behaviour.

7.3.3 Media of Persuasion

When we talk of an effective medium, it means comparing the persuasive advantage of each medium. Another issue is the likeability of the communicator affecting the persuasive abilities when it comes to electronic media messages audio–video. Written messages are held highly persuasive in the case of a source detracted by the messages from audio and video media formats. If we take individual differences into consideration, persuasiveness has its own dimensions as personality traits like self–esteem and intelligence. McGuire listed six observations as to the effectiveness of persuasion;

- 1) The meditational principle says personality characteristics affect persuasion.
- 2) The impact of personality on the mediating steps does vary.
- 3) The situational–weighting principle deals with varying import of different steps across different situations.
- 4) People with one personality characteristic will collect others who are differently related by persuasion.
- 5) The impact of personal factors depends upon source and message features.
- 6) A characteristic that makes an individual open to certain influences will make him resist persuasion in many others.

According to McGuire, there are no general principles of the impact of individual differences on persuasion. It means that mediated efforts affect different individuals in different ways and to different extent. Persuasion studies have shown people with low esteem do not easily understand the message. If they

understand the message; they may accept it due to lack of confidence in their own judgement. On the contrary, individuals with high esteem may understand the message and resist it. People with moderate esteem are open to persuasion. The inoculation theory also deals with resistance to persuasion.

We can see the persuasive functions of the media in the dissemination of information and entertainment as in advertising. Public relations, promotional events, image manipulation, and public opinion campaigns are other areas where persuasive techniques are employed. Editorials, letters to the editor and opinion columns are also open methods of persuasion. News columns, cartoons, music videos and other types of entertainment programmes contain personal, socioeconomic values.

We can safely assume that most part of persuasion in mass communication is hidden. For example, much of the news stories supplied by public relations practitioners are persuasive in character and origin. Most of what we get from mass media these days is planned to influence the public in some possible manner. Political campaigns are a staple diet of mass media, and are an act of persuasion. Similarly, most of government news is nothing but propaganda justifying the government decisions and win public support. A battery of professional PR Journalists working for MNCs employ techniques of persuasion in the financial and business news in media and is called advocacy journalism. Persuasion is one of the vital components of news.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Explain the use of fear appeals in mass communication.

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) Delineate the different aspects of hidden persuasion.

.....

.....

.....

.....

3) List the six observations of McGuire as to the effectiveness of persuasion.

.....

.....

.....

.....

7.4 PERSUASIVE ADVERTISING

Persuasive advertising is a type of marketing message intended to sell a product or service through persuasion. It aims to make a consumer to develop favourable attitude towards product resulting in actual purchase. It influences a consumer to buy the product on the sheer weight of arguments. Mass media all over the world heavily depend upon advertising revenue for survival. Every product on earth finds a place on media to reach out to buyers. Advertisers have found out the importance of persuasive messages in every form of media activity.

Features of Persuasive Advertising

- It is product promotion by convincing the consumer about the worth of the product
- It is not selling as consumer is not forced to buy a product but is convinced to buy.
- Here consumer makes up his/her own mind based on ad in favour of a product
- Information given is informal and convincing
- It encourages consumers to associate positive emotions with products
- It coaxes consumers to retain the brand against competition
- It aims to draw attention, sustain attention drawn and create a desire for the product to accept new behaviour.

Social psychologists have attempted to investigate the psychological differences among media users by manipulating media environments and messages on different groups of audience. Psychologists wanted to unravel the psychological differences among the audience members while sociologists were studying the media effects on different social categories. The 1940 presidential election in the United States brought into force the limited effects of mass media as to their persuasive abilities. Research on the presidential election discovered that the opinion leaders are more influential in persuading people through inter-personal channels. This led to the exposition of two-step flow theory of communication. Later it became multi-step flow theory. The adjunct professions of mass communication, both advertising and public relations, employ persuasive technique to influence different segments of media audience. These two professions excel in strategic communication.

7.4.1 Strategic Communication

Strategic communication is a comprehensive branch of study consisting of advertising, public relations, marketing and corporate communication. It is incorporating communication initiatives into a master plan to reach business goals. It is disseminating messages through appropriate channels to reach target audience to maximise desirable outcome. 'Strategic communications is an orchestrated use of channels of communication to move and influence public policy or to promote an agenda' (Emily Tynes). It is a deliberate, systematic plan to use communication to meet the agenda. The emphasis is more on making communication effective and hence persuasion gains significance in strategic communication. Both advertising and public relations adopt various techniques

of persuasive communication. They are considered as the process of employing mediated communication or messages to influence various publics to accept a new opinion, attitude or behaviour.

Historically, persuasive communication is attributed to the Greek philosopher, Aristotle whose classic work Rhetoric deals with persuasive communication. Classical rhetoricians employed a number of rhetorical devices to strongly present their arguments. Rhetoric was different from logic or philosophy in the sense that it was not about the truth of a matter. The sole aim was whether it could persuade target audience. It is stated that there are at least more than twenty theories related to persuasive communication and decision – making by audience. The theories provide us an insight into the different models and strategies of persuasive communication and they greatly help advertising and public relations practitioners to produce and promote strategic campaigns through various media.

All the theories of persuasive communication have three core elements in a linking chain such as the public, the media and the strategic communicators. The linkage has three portions:

- 1) The behaviours of the people or their actions are somewhat related to their cognition – knowledge or beliefs affect attitudes and emotions.
- 2) Mediated communication to some extent influence the cognition and affect behavioural change.
- 3) Mediated communication campaigns can be designed in causing cognitive, affective, and behavioural changes, the way it is intended.

AIDA Model

A widely used model based on these three assertions is called AIDA –attention / awareness, interest, desire and action. From the viewpoint of an advertiser, it is a hierarchical step–down process. The first level is drawing attention or creating awareness which should lead to next stage of generating interest. Once the attention drawn and interest sustained, the person moves towards the stage of desire for the product or service. From desire, s/he will move to the stage of action. Many factors affect the chain or process of mediated persuasion. A few of these are:

- 1) Media difference
- 2) Message features
- 3) Audience fragmentation, and
- 4) Individual characteristics

Media Difference factor means features of each medium vary. For instance, if you take print and compare it with electronic media, the differences are visible. Print deals with space and the electronic media with time. The style of presentation differs. Similarly, we speak of interactive and passive media. The qualities of message are its characteristics. For example, the level of complexity, extent of credibility, emotionality, or quality of information supplied make for message qualities. With the rapid expansion of media in terms of numbers and interests in recent times made the audience fragment, creating a minuscule audience for each channel or medium.

This has happened because of wide variety of media choice. However, this has complicated the job of advertising and public relations professionals, as they cannot easily reach out to large audiences. Individual characteristics and conditions mean the demographic factors like age, gender, nationality or race or ethnicity, geographical location, psychographic factors, perceptions of people, thinking and interventions, media habits shaping public taste, opinion, preference, behaviour and knowledge. As a result, strategic communicators – advertising and PR professionals use all their knowledge and experience to choose media channels to reach specialised or fragmented audiences.

7.4.2 Persuasion for Social Change

Can we use persuasive communication to bring in social change? Research has shown that media has the potential to cause social change. Positive social objectives can be achieved both at individual and collective levels. For example, a public service campaign to make people quit smoking. Most research on television in the early stage was done to find out the power of mediated messages to persuade audience to gain acceptance. Early efforts focused on how media could influence the audience. As such, media influence was found to depend upon following factors;

- 1) Characteristics of the communication source
- 2) Nature of the message
- 3) Media characteristics
- 4) Audience

Carl Hovland, Irving Janis and Harold H. Kelley of Yale University conducted research on Communication and Attitude Change between 1946 and 1961. Of course, they conducted research in the controlled laboratory atmosphere, rather than in the actual media field. Their intention was to control factors like message, source, or others leading to the role of stimulus-response in changing the audience attitude. Their research proved that the credibility of the source is a significant variable that shapes the persuasiveness of the media message. More expertise and trust worthiness means more persuasive compared to a person whose expertness is always questioned. An article in a well-known and reputed magazine is considered more credible than that of a gossip columnist.

The researchers also identified a number of message factors that could affect the persuasiveness of a communication. Strong fear appeals make people to act. It was also found out that the structure of the message should also be taken into consideration. However, it should properly fit into the receptor. Hovland et al found the influence of audience factors like personality variables, group affiliation, and the extent of audience involvement in the message as to its persuasiveness. Agenda-setting process and the role of newspaper in particular in setting primary agenda of issues have been studied. It is also found out the role of television in setting priorities of the agenda items set for public discussion.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Evaluate the persuasive dimension of advertising.

.....

.....

.....

2) Amplify the concept of strategic communication.

.....

.....

.....

3) What factors affect the use of persuasion for change in the society?

.....

.....

.....

7.5 LET US SUM UP

The phenomenon of persuasion has been an interesting topic for academicians and professionals alike. In modern days, Advertising and Public Relations professionals use persuasion techniques to get favourable response to maximise profit. In this unit we discussed various aspects of the role of media in attitudinal change and persuasion.

A systematic study of attitude change began in the early part of the 20th century. The World War II offered an opportunity to study attitude change and the media role in it. Carl Hovland and his team studied psychological barriers to persuasion and prepare messages to overcome them, with particular reference to American soldiers. Hovland and his group produced documentaries and orientation movies to motivate the soldiers. He used the technique of controlled variation to assess the influence of elements of media contents on human attitude. He concluded that military propaganda was not all that powerful as imagined.

Time is a major variable in attitude change. An important principle of attitude change theory is cognitive consistency. Leon Festinger's theory of cognitive dissonance says that information not consistent with a person's values and beliefs held by him will produce psychological discomfort or dissonance, which must be removed. The defence mechanism to hold one's own values and beliefs in the selection of media content are done by selective exposure, selective retention, and selective perception.

McGuire prepared a linear model of persuasion, which contained independent variables like the characteristics of source, message, channel, receiver, and

destination. The theory of classical conditioning speaks of unconditional stimulus, unconditional response, and conditional stimulus. The experiment of Russian psychologist Ivan Pavlov should be mentioned here. The concept of reward and punishment is related to operant or instrumental conditioning popularised by B.F. Skinner. The functional theories of attitudes consider individuals as highly irrational.

The credibility of the communicator is an important factor in persuasive communication. There is also a correlation between time and credibility level. Fear appeals have been widely used in advertisements. They are considered as attitude changers. Increased fear may result in message-consistent attitude to a limited extent. Lower fear appeals are more effective with highly anxious people. Deception can be implied in advertising messages.

Subliminal advertising is hidden or indirect. However, subliminal effects have a limited power in a laboratory setting. When we talk of an effective medium, it means comparing the persuasive advantage of each medium. There is also a comparison between opinion leaders and media sources as effective carriers of persuasive messages. McGuire has listed six observations as regards the effectiveness of persuasion. People with moderate esteem are amenable to persuasion. Promotional events, image manipulations and public opinion campaigns, editorials, letters to the editor and opinion columns are open methods of persuasion. We can assume that most part of persuasion in mass communication is hidden and is widely believed that much part of news is persuasion.

The earlier theory of unlimited and powerful effects of mass media paved way for the limited effect theory. Inter-personal channels like opinion leaders are deemed as more effective than media channels. The multi-step flow hypothesis is the extension of two-step flow theory. Advertising and public relations excel in strategic communication, using persuasive techniques. Media differences, message features, audience division and individual characteristics and conditions affect the process of mediated communication. The role of television in agenda-setting as a persuasive communicator has been widely studied.

7.6 FURTHER READINGS

Black, Jay and Jennings Bryant (1992), Introduction to Mass Communication, Dubuque (USA), Wm.C. Brown Publishers

Pavlik, John and Shaun McIntosh (2004), Converging Media: An Introduction to Mass Communication, Boston (USA), Pearson Education, Inc.

Baran, Stanley J and Dennis K. Davis (2012), Mass Communication Theory: Foundations, Ferment and Future, Boston (USA), Wadsworth

Perry, David K (2002), Theory and Research in Mass Communication: Contexts and Consequences, New Jersey (USA), Lawrence Erlbaum Associate.

7.7 KEY TERMS

Cognitive consistency: Media messages consistent with the values and beliefs of the people.

Classical conditioning: The biological instinct to respond to the stimulus provided. Ivan Pavlov's experiment is an example.

Operant or instrumental conditioning: The use of punishment or reward as learning means.

Balance theory: This theory of Heider says that people adjust their attitudes and behaviours to accommodate self-interest, communication and pressure from others.

Rhetoric: A concept of persuasive communication used by Greek philosopher Aristotle.

7.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Attitude can be termed as a generalised intention to behave in a certain manner towards a certain object. Behaviour is a response of a person to a stimulus, an action, a person, or an event. Behaviour has the element of immediacy.
- 2) McGuire prepared a linear model of persuasion, which had five types of independent variables such as the characteristics of the source, message, channel, receiver and destination. The dependent variables in sequence are presentation, attention, comprehension, yielding, retention, and overt behaviour.
- 3) Carl Hovland and his team worked for the Experimental Section of the Information and Education Division of the US army. They produced documentaries and orientation movie series called *Why We Fight* under the supervision of well-known Hollywood director Frank Capra to motivate the American soldiers. Hovland used controlled variation to evaluate the impact of media content on human attitudes. Hovland and his group found out that the military propaganda was not at all powerful, as imagined earlier.
- 4) Leon Festinger is the person behind the theory of cognitive dissonance. According to this theory, information not consistent with a person's values and beliefs, already held by him, will produce a psychological discomfort and must be removed. The person attempts to make the information consistent through a defense mechanism called selective process.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) Mass media normally use fear appeals as a technique of persuasion. Newspaper editors worry about political corruption at the cost of ethical values that makes us fearful of the future of our society. Media persons scare audience to change their attitude. Fear appeals can be classified as low, modest and high. Advertisers use fear appeals to lure people towards their products and services. Deception is also used as part of persuasive process. A high dose of fear may lead to message resistance.

- 2) Subliminal advertising is hidden persuasion. Vance Packard was the person behind this thought. Subliminal effects have limited power in a laboratory environment. Certain untrustworthy messages may lead to after-the-effect realisation though initially accepted. Television sets may not offer stimulus at short gaps of time for subliminal persuasion to take place. Sometimes, there may not be much difference between hidden and other forms of persuasion.
- 3) The six observations of McGuire about persuasion are:
 - a) Personality characteristics affect persuasion.
 - b) Impact of personality on the mediating steps varies.
 - c) There is varying meaning of different steps across different situations.
 - d) People with one characteristic will collect others differently related by persuasion.
 - e) The impact of personal factors depends upon source message features.
 - f) If a characteristic makes a person accept certain influence, these may make him resist persuasion in many others.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Mass media functions of information supply and entertainment have the element of persuasion. Advertising does both functions. Huge amounts of money are spent on mass media advertisements. Advertising is the backbone of mass media to survive. Advertisements persuade people to buy a product or service. Most advertisements have the hidden messages of persuasion.
- 2) The purpose of advertising through strategic communication is achieved by advertisers when they buy media space or time. They want to influence people through commercial messages. Public relations practitioners do this job by organising communication campaigns and try to get media space and time without payment. Both advertising and public relations adopt various techniques of persuasive communication. They produce and promote strategic campaigns by employing various media channels.
- 3) Media can be used for positive social change through persuasive public campaigns. Positive social objectives can be achieved at both individual and collective levels. Factors that affect the persuasive communication in this regard are: characteristics of the communication source, nature of the message, media characteristics and the audience. The credibility of the source and appropriate appeal in the message are also important.

UNIT 8 THEORIES OF LEARNING

Structure

- 8.0 Introduction
- 8.1 Learning Outcomes
- 8.2 Theory of Developmental Learning
 - 8.2.1 Four Stages
 - 8.2.2 Learning from Media
- 8.3 Learning Socialisation
 - 8.3.1 Situated Knowledge
 - 8.3.2 Inquiry-based Learning
 - 8.3.3 Interaction
 - 8.3.4 Framing
- 8.4 Attributes of Learning
 - 8.4.1 Categories
 - 8.4.2 Causal Mechanisms
- 8.5 Social Learning Theory
 - 8.5.1 Identification
 - 8.5.2 Social Learning
- 8.6 Social Cognition Theory
 - 8.6.1 Representations
 - 8.6.2 Direct Influence
- 8.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 8.8 Further Readings
- 8.9 Key Terms
- 8.10 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

8.0 INTRODUCTION

The functions of mass media range from supply of information to transmission of culture. Even though one of the main functions of media is to impart education, it is not formal education in the real sense of the term. Often, media are referred to as ‘common man’s university.’ It is also a fact that some educationists are skeptical as to the utility of media in the classroom. For them, mere supply of information is not knowledge. Audio-visual tools have become part and parcel of classroom academics of the day.

Media consumption is a dominant activity of childhood. The Kaiser Family Foundation and Annenberg School studies have proved the dominance of mediated communication in everyday life of children in the United States. Of course, television and Internet are the favourite media of children. As per the recent studies, video games have a profound effect on children. Irrespective of age, the studies have found that boys devote more time watching television and playing video games than girls. By this, we can safely assume that today’s children live in a media saturated world and quickly adopt the newer interactive media.

8.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- describe the theory of developmental learning;
- identify the attributes of causal mechanisms of learning;
- evaluate the theory of social learning; and
- assess the social cognition theory's importance as a psychological base for research.

8.2 THEORY OF DEVELOPMENTAL LEARNING

What and how do children learn from television, to which most children are highly exposed? The process known as developmental learning is the answer. Accordingly, children's intellectual capacity passes through many stages of increased ability. This theory is the outcome of research conducted by a Swiss psychologist Jean Piaget (1896-1980). He wanted to know the process of learning by children. Strange it may appear, but he conducted most of his research on his own children, by closely monitoring their intellectual growth from infancy to a particular age level. From his studies, Piaget identified the four stages of development of cognitive capability among children, discussed below:

8.2.1 Four Stages

- 1) **Sensorimotor:** During the first two years of life, infants are aware of sensorimotor experiences. However, they cannot link their experiences to things outside, external of themselves. They understand very little as to how things would react. Because of this, we can see children putting things in their mouth, shaking them and frequently experimenting. It is an effort to learn by the trial and error method.
- 2) **Pre-operational:** From 18-24 months of age to 7 years, children pass through pre-operational stage. Here they start thinking about things in a symbolic way, language in particular. In this phase, they develop their imagination, can speak out their thoughts and understand concepts of the past and the future. They can also distinguish between what is real and what is fantasy.
- 3) **Concrete operations:** Between age 7 to 12 years, children develop the ability to analyse issues in a systematic manner and also view things from the perspective of others.
- 4) **Formal operations:** Once children cross the age of 12, they start to think in abstraction, can formulate hypotheses and understand concepts like democracy, justice, empowerment, and others. They can also examine the consequences of actions.

8.2.2 Learning from Media

Several media scholars have used Piaget's theory in their studies to know how children learn from television as well as other media. What they learn is influenced by their stage of development. Children who are in infancy cannot read and

write but they can learn much from viewing television, especially what is right and wrong, the reward and punishment aspects of life. In the next stage, children are exposed to reading and writing. They can learn and understand the symbolic messages of television. For example, the role of men and women, parents and teachers and it can also teach them the value of money. Children of the age between 7 and 12 years can develop a critical thinking of what they view on television. At stage four, the final stage of development, children have a higher level of understanding. They can learn and understand issues related to violence, history, science, freedom and many others. Since this is the stage of adolescence, the social meaning of television assumes importance. Children's demands from television mature go beyond cartoons and comedy.

Research has also shown that how TV commercials teach children to buy. It is said that children are susceptible to commercials on TV. For example, many products and services target children to influence parents in buying decisions. Here children are not direct users but have the potential to influence parents to buy car, fridge, credit cards, and washing machine. Television programmes also provide lessons about people's expected behaviour in society. Learning social lessons and stereotypes in society is another dimension of the educational role of media.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of this unit.

- 1) Identify the four stages of development of cognitive capability among children.

.....

.....

.....

- 2) What do children learn from the symbolic messages of television?

.....

.....

.....

8.3 LEARNING SOCIALISATION

Ellen A Wartella et al have studied different dimensions of learning socialisation from media vis-à-vis children's cognitive development. They wanted to know how and what children want from media. Aspects of such thinking normally deal with variables like language socialisation, education and learning, mind, self and society, social cognitive development, and dialogue. These dimensions are used to understand the role of media in learning. Socialisation is described as the process of acquiring roles, skills, and knowledge needed to execute the role by individuals. We face new challenges of a new situation with whatever resources we can bring – called situated knowledge, assistance of fellow performers (scaffolding), discovery and acquisition of new resources (inquiry),

communication to involve others in our learning (dialogue), a view of making sense of new activities and decide how to use what we are learning (framing).

8.3.1 Situated Knowledge

An important theory of human development considers cognitive growth as acquiring situated knowledge apart from skills. It is the result of learning how to execute roles in well-defined activities. Learning is situation-specific. For example, use of one tool cannot be generalised with the use of another. A grass-mower is different from a sewing machine. Because of the situated feature of knowledge and skills, it is difficult to show the impact of media experience on common cognitive development. Different media that may have different representational systems encourage children to acquire different types of cognitive skills. We must also note that the media is not the only factor to affect our perception or cognition.

Performance and dialogue help us acquire situated knowledge. Performance and dialogue, on one hand, are produced and understood in relation to particular social activities. As a matter of fact, communication plays a vital role in acquiring the situated knowledge. Again, socialising agents such as parents, siblings, teachers, and peers teach children through communication to learn new activities.

In the apprenticeship mode of learning, knowledge is gained while doing the work. In a similar vein, parents and others support children in learning about how to use verbal communication. Across cultures, parents extend instruction to their children on the use of language. Besides parents, formal characteristics of media presentations also help children in learning. Some formal characteristics of television content are called 'syntax of television'. These are single words, repetitions, and literal meanings used in the programmes. Actions and labels help in the recall of objects, events, and characters. They also aid in information processing by children. These kind of supports for children's learning are labelled as 'scaffolding'. This allows children to learn to reproduce the activity and also the content. Learning starts from observation and then by participating more and more in complex activities, with decreasing help from others. As knowledge and skill increase, the participant becomes an independent learner.

8.3.2 Inquiry-based Learning

In the apprentice-mode of learning the emphasis is on inquiry. Concepts of inquiry for learning can be seen in the works and philosophy of John Dewey. All learning theories accept that children are quick and active learners. Piaget speaks of active child in the process of intellectual development. His view is always referred to as constructivist. To him, children develop an understanding of the world through active participation, not by passive observation. One other view called constructionism says that knowledge is not simply transmitted from teachers to students, but it is constructed by the learner. It is said that, when children participate in learning, they create new ideas.

Now-a-days scholars emphasise on dialogue as a powerful tool of inquiry. Dialogue can be face-to-face or mediated. Dialogue provides scope, not only for scaffolding, but also to communicate their ideas. Dialogue is inter-personal communication and social interaction in the process of learning. The three elements important for the theory of dialogue are identity, interaction, and

collaboration. Identity means the social self - it is person who is in a social situation. In every society, identities are communicated - identity is socially situated and keeps on changing.

8.3.3 Interaction

Media have various types and degrees of interactivity. If there is no floor for participation, that particular medium does not become interactive. For instance, broadcast television does not provide for participatory space while computer-based communication permits for shared participation. In some media, the floor is simple. But in interactive media, shared message space is complex. Depending upon the type of participation, media selection also differs. Media can be synchronous or asynchronous. Media also differ according to the degree or extent of participation they can sustain. Collaboration is the third and final element of dialogue. The context of shared effort makes dialogue possible. Collaboration helps in achieving more mature performances. Collaboration with peers is essential for the cognitive development of children. Besides, children have the natural ability to seek and support co-operative efforts that can increase their learning abilities.

8.3.4 Framing

Framing is another dimension of communicative learning. Framing is the way a communication source defines and constructs a message. It is inevitable in human communication as we all add our own meaning to a message and we always bring our own frame to our communication. Framing is placing information within a field of meaning. According to Sarr (1996) framing consists of three elements: language, thought and forethought. Language is essential in transmission of information and thought helps in interpretation and forethought is about predict framing opportunities whether is it possible to add frames to the message and if so how. For example, the newspaper frames news with a certain point of view and this can change the perception of readers about a particular issue. So, an issue is presented with a different meaning to make audience understand it in that perspective. Children are presented information with a different field of meaning to make them perceive it from that perspective and that is another dimension of learning through framing.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

- 1) What children want from mediated communication, according to researchers?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

- 2) Briefly explain the following concepts identified in relation to the cognitive development among children.
 - 1) Situated knowledge
 - 2) Scaffolding
 - 3) Inquiry
 - 4) Dialogue
 - 5) Framing
- 3) Analyse the role of media in the process of learning.

.....

.....

.....

8.4 ATTRIBUTES OF LEARNING

Let us get back to the question; do mass media really influence our learning habits? We do know that we are exposed to contradictory views – ranging from extremely positive to extremely negative. Of course, some scholars have attempted to tread a middle path. A well-known educational scholar, Richard Clark (1983) in his study concluded that media do not influence learning, but are merely vehicles of instruction delivery. Media have nothing to do with student achievement in a formal instruction.

In order to understand the importance of media in learning, we have to go beyond the saying that media are mere vehicles of delivery. With the arrival of digital technology, followed by media convergence, multi-media instruction has become a reality. Doubtless, the new information and communication technology has made the concept of edutainment possible on a large scale.

8.4.1 Categories

As you are aware, communication is of different types, starting from verbal to non-verbal, depending upon the nature of communication. Media are similarly categorised based on the mode and technology used. In the same fashion, media stimuli are classified in relation to their technological features and their effects on learning, which are based on a pre-set test. Many of such tests or studies do not offer descriptions of cognitive, affective, or social factors responsible for making learning possible. At the same time, research efforts do not have the description of media structures and functions responsible for causal factors, influencing these processes. For some scholars, a medium is a vehicle of stimuli to which the learner makes behavioural responses. Learning is not an automatic response to delivery of instruction. On the contrary, learning is active, constructive, cognitive and social. As a consequence, a learner has to manage cognitive, physical and social resources to produce new knowledge. We should also remember here that knowledge and learning do not constitute a non-transferable property of any individual or the environment.

8.4.2 Causal Mechanisms

The next important assertion is that the relationship between media and learning is an interaction, mediated between cognitive processes and the environment. If we want to understand the role of media in learning, it is obviously necessary to have a media theory in the cognitive and social processes by which knowledge is produced. It means that we must consider the structure and causal mechanisms of media, in terms of their interaction with cognitive and social processes. Media technology, symbol systems and processing abilities are included in these processes. Technology is defined as the physical, mechanical or even electronic capabilities of a medium. These shape the functions of a medium. The outwardly features help us identify a medium as radio or television. The spoken language, pictures, the printed text, the musical scores, maps, graphs and types of representations are the symbol systems. The processing capability includes the ability of a medium to operate using the symbol system in defined ways.

In terms of its capabilities, each medium is different. Each one does certain functions in interaction with learners. Learning with the support of media can be best described as a complementary process. Media help learners understand the difficult social contexts easily. Electronic media including video present learners details and information important to solve complex issues.

The visual and social nature of the text or story will activate relevant knowledge to assist learners solve the problems posed. The capability and variability of a medium's use must be differentiated. We must note that the attributes of a medium are its capabilities, always present in the medium. For effective learning, an integration of media and methods in the educational context is highly preferable. We should also note that traditional models of instructional designs do not suffice the needs of learners in the contemporary world. Therefore, there exists a need for rework the entire strategic approach. By this, media attributes can be effectively combined with educational or instructional designs to achieve the desired goals.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

- 1) Do you agree with the assertion that media are mere vehicles of instruction delivery? Justify your view.

.....

.....

.....

- 2) Examine media as an attribute of learning.

.....

.....

.....

3) What does the term 'causal mechanisms of learning' mean?

.....

.....

.....

8.5 SOCIAL LEARNING THEORY

Observation is the basis of all human learning. The moot question here is what type of behaviour and how much people can learn from the media. In social psychology, we discuss a phenomenon called "imitation". Do we really imitate what we see, hear, or read in the media? Imitation is described as 'the direct mechanical reproduction of behaviour'. There have been examples of imitation of behaviour shown on the television or cinema screen by the audience. An example of this is the issue of effects of television violence on children.

8.5.1 Identification

In the context of social learning, we also use another term, 'identification', which is described as a different form of imitation that comes out from wanting to be and trying to be like an observed model with some extra characteristics. People do imitate, but how many of them identify themselves with the media characters they come across? It is observed that identification with media models is more lasting and reflects powerful media effects. Imitation of media characters is more dramatic and observable than identification. Psychologists Neal Miller and John Dollard (1941) were said to be the first to think of learning through observation. According to them, the imitative learning takes place among observes who are motivated to learn.

Ultimately people can imitate behaviours they see. Behaviours can be reinforced to learn. Miller and Dollard did not detail that how people learn from models, including the media models. They only described an effective method of traditional stimulus–response learning. To them, individuals behaved in particular ways and built their behaviour in association with the reinforcement they received. Accordingly, the trial and error method was replaced by imitation. It made easier for an individual to select behaviour to be reinforced. Miller and Dollard posited that actual reinforcement guaranteed learning.

8.5.2 Social Learning

After many experiments, Miller and Dollard called their hypothesis as social learning. Their ideas became fully developed to understand the media effects on learning. They considered social learning as an efficient form of stimulus–response learning. The model provided information that helped the observer to select the correct response to be reinforced. The present day social cognitive theory, the new title for social learning theory, says that people can acquire symbolic representation of the behaviour and it will give them the information to shape their later behaviour, media characters can affect their behaviour after being shown on the screen. The media audience need not have reinforcement or reward for the change in their social behaviour.

There is another name associated with the social learning theory. According to Jay Black, Jennings Bryant, Albert Bandura, a well-known psychologist was its founder and the theory has been extensively used by mass communication researchers. According to this theory media are active educators, but what they do is very subtle and indirect. The media teach people about the world around them. An example of television is given here. The audiences are frequently exposed to this medium. Hence, it is considered as a medium capable of teaching its audience both positive and negative attitudes and behaviours.

People might not come to experience it on their own and may not learn from non-mediated exposures. Social learning scholars diligently listed a number of conditions by which mediated behaviours are modelled or not. They have also found out the processes to explain why and how these behaviours have the possibility of being performed after learning from media exposure. Albert Bandura is one of those scholars responsible for listing such conditions. As already stated, the assertion that people learn from observation, the core factor of the social learning theory, is important for media researchers. The theory is used widely in relation to the learning capabilities of children, as described earlier. The theory has also been employed to show that children possibly model their pro-social behaviours when they see them in mass media.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

- 1) Distinguish between imitation and identification in the context of social learning.

.....

.....

.....

- 2) Describe the concept of social learning as posited by Neal Miller and John Dollard.

.....

.....

.....

- 3) Are media active educators?

.....

.....

.....

8.6 SOCIAL COGNITION THEORY

Social cognition is the contemporary term for social learning. The theory also speaks of behavioural learning. When people respond to stimuli, their responses

are reinforced either positively or negatively. However, two important assumptions are to be noted here. The first one – this is an insufficient method of learning. According to the operant or traditional learning theory, when each individual is presented with a stimulus, s/he will have chance response. It may be negative in character or a negative reinforce. In different settings, on the contrary, mass mediated or otherwise, we add avoidance to the behaviours of everyday stimulus. It means we have a substitute representation, an experience for an actual experience. The second assumption is that we not only learn in the traditional manner, but otherwise also.

All of us learn through observation, even when there is no stimulus–response–reinforcement linkage. Modelling from the mass media is an efficient method to learn a range of behaviours and find solutions to the problems otherwise we will learn the behaviours slowly or do not learn at all. Alternatively, we may pay heavily to learn in the real environment.

Learning from observation of the environment is the main principle of social cognitive theory. According to the theory, mass media can affect people's behaviours and that effect will be or is influenced by personal factors particular to the people and their situations. Social cognition through media representations functions in one or more of three ways.

8.6.1 Representations

- 1) **Observational learning:** Consumers of representation can acquire new patterns of behaviour by viewing such representations.
- 2) **Inhibitory effects:** If we see a person being punished for certain behaviour, the likelihood of our behaving in the same way decreases. It is said that it is the viewers who are punished. Such representations can inhibit among observers behaviours like aggressiveness, exploratory mentality, or even anti-social interactions with others in the society.
- 3) **Disinhibitory effects:** A media representation that depicts reward for pursuing a prohibitory behaviour is considered enough to increase the likelihood of the consumer of the representation will make that response. Reduced fear of dentists, dogs and snakes can be given as an example for this.

Vicarious reinforcement is the basis of social cognition through mass media. As a matter of fact, observational learning can happen without any reinforcement, vicarious or otherwise. When we feel ourselves rewarded or punished after seeing a television character being rewarded or punished for some behaviour, it is called 'vicarious reinforcement'. This tells us where to place the learned behaviour, an outcome of observation, in our behavioural hierarchy. There is no need to actually experience the rewards and punishment. We can experience them vicariously through the use of media representations. There are occasions when we ignore possible negative consequences and show behaviour associated with punishment or restriction. Then take it up in the hierarchy to a point where we can select it from among a number of alternatives. Albert Bandura called it as 'social prompting'.

8.6.2 Direct Influence

Bandura conducted an experiment in 1965 on modeling aggressive behaviour from television that had a direct influence on many aspects of the debate on media effects.

The strong points of social cognitive theory are:

- It displays causal link between media and behaviour.
- It can be applied across many viewers and viewing situations.
- The theory has a strong power of explanation.

Some of its limitations are:

- It suffers from the problem of generalisation, because it cannot be applied to every situation.
- Possibilities of over-estimation of media power exist.
- The theory has failed to explain the long-term effects of media consumption.
- The theory underestimates people's active use of mediated messages.
- It has narrow focus on individuals rather than cultural effects.

Check Your Progress 5

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer:

2) Compare your answer with those given at the end of the unit

- 1) Delineate the two assumptions embedded in the social cognitive theory.

.....

.....

.....

- 2) Outline the three approaches that social cognition functions through media representations.

.....

.....

.....

- 3) What are the strengths and limitaitons of the social cognition theory?

.....

.....

.....

8.7 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we discussed that the function of mass media in the modern day world is well defined and categorised. It ranges from the supply of information to transmission of culture across space and time. Media do not impart formal education in the real sense of the term. They can, at best, impart informal

education, by informing the media consumers about the world, events and people around. Initially, many educationists were skeptical of the utility of media content in the classroom. However, the new information and communication technology has made possible the use of media in academic portals, teaching, and research. When it is media content consumption, children are in the forefront. Children spend more time for use of media than any other activity. Research studies have proved the dominance of mediated communication in the everyday life of children. Television and Internet, apart from video games, are favourite media. It is said media use helps in the evolutionary growth of children adults.

One of the early theories related with the issue of media exposure of children is the theory of developmental learning. It was advocated by Jean Piaget, a Swiss psychologist. It is a theoretical approach which says that learning is an evolutionary process. Accordingly, children's intellectual capacity passes through many stages of increased ability. Piaget through his research identified the four stages of development of cognitive capability such as: sensorimotor, pre-operational, concrete operations and formal operations.

Ellen A Wartella et al have studied different dimensions of learning socialisation from different types of media vis-a-vis children's cognitive development. They intended to know how and what children want from media. The aspects of such thinking deal with the nature of language socialisation, nature of education and learning, mind, self and society, social cognitive development and dialogue. These dimensions can be used to understand the role of media in learning socialisation, besides skills and knowledge to execute the roles prescribed. All of us face new challenges of new situations in our lives regularly with whatever resources we can bring in such as situated knowledge, assistance of fellow performers (scaffolding), discovery and acquisition of new resources (inquiry) and communication to involve others in our learning (dialogue). In addition is a view of making sense of new activities and decide how to use what we are learning (training). The researchers say that learning is situation specific.

Parents, teachers, and others help children learn verbal communication. Some formal characteristics of television contents are called 'Syntax of television'. These are single words, receptions, and literal meanings used in the programmes. Actions and labels help in the recall of objects, events and characters, besides working as aid in information processing by children. Inquiry is the major component of apprentice-mode of learning. Framing provides the context to interpret communicated messages.

Some scholars like Richard Clark state that media do not influence learning, but are merely vehicles of instruction delivery, while others have not agreed with such findings. Learning is not an automatic response to delivery of instruction. On the other, a learner has to manage cognitive, physical and social resources to produce knowledge. The relation between media and learning is an interaction mediated between cognitive processes and the environment.

Observation is the basis of human learning. In Social Psychology, we discuss a phenomenon known as 'imitation'. There have been examples of imitation of behaviour shown on television or in movies. We can here mention the television violence impacting children. In the context of social learning, we also use the term 'identification'. Identification with media models are more lasting than

imitation. Neal Miller and John Dollard are considered to be the originators of this theory. According to them, the imitative learning takes place among observers who are motivated to learn. They considered social learning as an efficient form of stimulus–response learning.

Another name associated with social learning theory is that of Albert Bandura. His theory has been extensively used in mass communication research. For him, the media are active educators, but what they do is very subtle, and indirect. The example of television is given here as a medium capable of teaching its audience, both positive and negative attitudes and behaviours. The theory has been employed to show that children possibly model their pro-social behaviours when they see them in mass media programmes.

Social cognition is the contemporary term for social learning. It also speaks of behavioural learning, when people respond to stimuli; their responses are reinforced either positively or negatively. The two important assumptions of the theory are:

- 1) This is an insufficient method of learning and
- 2) We not only learn in the traditional or operant manner, but otherwise also.

Learning from observation of the environment is the main principle of social cognitive theory. The theory says that mass media can affect people's behaviours that effect will be or is influenced by personal factors specific to the people and their situations. Social cognition through media representations functions through observational learning. There are inhibitory effects of media exposure. Viewing a person being punished for a behaviour not accepted will inhibit others from anti-social behaviour. Vicarious reinforcement is another factor of social cognition. Both rewards and punishments are basis for vicarious reinforcement. Social cognition theory has its own merits and demerits.

8.8 FURTHER READINGS

Baran, Stanley J and Dennis K. Davis (2012), Mass Communication Theory: Foundations, Ferment and Future, Boston (USA), Wadsworth.

Black Jay and Jennings Bryant (1992), Introduction to Mass Communication, Dubuque (USA), Wm. C. Brown Publishers.

Fortner, Robert S and P. Mark Feckler (ed) (2014), The Handbook of Media and Mass Communication Theory, Malden (USA), John Wiley and Sons Inc.

Kazma, Robert B (1991), Will Media Influence Learning? Reframe the Debate, Review of Educational Research, 61(2), 179-212.

Pavlik John and Shawn McIntosh (2004), Converging Media: An Introduction to Mass Communication, Boston (USA), Pearson Education, Inc.

8.9 KEY TERMS

Cognition: Mental process or action of acquiring knowledge; perception, thinking, reasoning.

Socialisation: It is a process of acquiring roles and also the skills and knowledge to execute these roles.

Syntax of television: Single words, repetitions and literal meanings used in television programmes.

Social prompting: Ignoring negative consequences displaying a behaviour associated with punishment or restriction.

Vicarious reinforcement: When we feel we ourselves are rewarded or punished after seeing a television character for some behaviour.

8.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS : POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) The four stages of development of cognition capabilities of children are:
 - i) Sensorimotor
 - ii) Pre-operational
 - iii) Concrete operations
 - iv) Formal operations
- 2) In the second stage of their growth, between 18-24 months, children are exposed to reading and writing. They can learn and understand the symbolic messages of television.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) According to researchers, children learn from media the language socialisation; education and learning; mind, self and society; social cognitive development and dialogue.
- 2)
 - a) **Situated knowledge:** Facing new challenges of a new situation with whatever resource we can bring. It is the result of learning how to perform roles in defined activities. Communication depends upon situated knowledge.
 - b) **Scaffolding:** It is assistance or support from fellow performers. Parents and others help children. Apart from these, media also supports them. For example, there is a phenomenon called 'syntax of television'. It contains single words, repetitions, and literal meanings used in TV programmes. Actions and labels help recall objects, events, and characters and aid in information processing by children. These are called 'scaffolding'.
 - c) **The inquiry-based learning** is the basis of apprentice mode. Concepts of inquiry for learning can be seen in the works and philosophy of John Dewey. According to Piaget, children develop the understanding of the world through active participation, not by passive observation. Children create new ideas by active participation.
 - d) **Dialogue:** When we involve others in our learning, it leads to dialogue. Today the stress is on dialogue in learning as it is a powerful tool of

inquiry. It also provides scope for scaffolding and also to communicate their ideas. Dialogue is interpersonal communication and social interaction in the process of learning. The three important elements of dialogue are identity, interaction, and collaboration.

- e) **Framing:** It is a view of making sense of new activities and decides how to use what we are learning. The message frame can focus on knowledge of message point, topic or much needed background information, or may have the context for the interpretation of communication. People learning from communication narratives are directly related to the frames they have been given.
- 3) With digital technology, media have leap frogged in their functions and features. The symbol systems that media use make them unique. The multimedia presentations have changed the instructional environment. The interactive media can affect the cognition, emotions, social relation and even the physical health of children.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Richard Clark stated that media do not influence learning, but are merely vehicles of instruction delivery. However, due to certain developments in the field of educational technology, especially new digital media platforms have made video instruction and tutorials popular with the youth.
- 2) Digital technology, media convergence and multimedia instruction have made mediated learning very important. The concept of edutainment is also gaining popularity. The issue is to go beyond the behavioural approach of stimulus response model. Media do influence the cognitive, affective, and social processes of individuals.
- 3) If we want to learn the role of media in learning, it is necessary to have a media theory in the cognitive and social processes by which knowledge is produced. In other words, we must consider the structure and causal mechanisms of media, in terms of their interaction with cognitive and social processes. Media technology, symbol systems, and processing abilities are part of the process.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) The concept of imitation is 'the direct mechanical reproduction of behaviour'. It can be positive or negative. Identification is a distinct form of imitation in which the individual wants to be or trying to be an observed model of his/her broader qualities. Identification with media models lasts longer than imitation.
- 2) According to psychologists John Dollard and Neal Miller the imitative learning takes place among observers who are motivated to learn. However, the elements of the behaviour to be learnt must be present so that people can imitate behaviours they see. Behaviours can be reinforced. It is simply an effective method of traditional stimulus response learning. The trial and error method of learning is replaced by imitation. To them, actual reinforcement guarantees learning.

- 3) According to Albert Bandura, media are active educators, but subtle and indirect. The media teach people about the world around them which can be both positive and negative attitude and behaviour. What people cannot experience on their own can be brought into their personal world through media exposure.

Check Your Progress 5

- 1) The two important assumptions of the social cognitive theory are:
 - a) According to operant or traditional learning theory, when each individual is presented with a stimulus he or she will have a chance response. It may be negative in character or a negative reinforce.
 - b) We not only learn in the traditional fashion, but otherwise also. All of us learn through observation, even when there is no stimulus response reinforcement linkage. Modeling from mass media is an efficient way of learning.
- 2) The three approaches are:
 - 1) **Observational learning:** Consumers of representation can acquire new patterns of behaviour by viewing such representations.
 - 2) **Inhibitory effects:** If we see a person is being punished for a behaviour, it will have a deterrent effect on others, who view it. The likelihood of us behaving the same way is decreased.
 - 3) **Disinhibitory effects:** A media representation that depicts reward for pursuing a prohibitory behaviour is considered enough to increase the likelihood of making such a response. For example, fear of snakes and dogs.
- 3) The strong points of social cognitive theory are :
 - a) It provides causal link between media and behaviour.
 - b) It can be applied across several viewers and viewing situations.
 - c) It has a strong power of explanation.

The limitations are:

- a) It suffers from the problem of generalisation as it cannot be applied to every situation.
- b) Over-estimation of media power is possible.
- c) The theory has failed to explain the long term effects of media consumption.
- d) It underestimates people's active use of mediated messages.
- e) It has a narrow focus on individuals rather than cultural effects.

REFERENCES

Choices and Preference in Media Use: Advances in Selective Exposure Theory & Research, Routledge Communication Series.

The Social Media Silo Situation – Kellie Colunga; <https://viewpoint.pointloma.edu/the-social-media-silo-situation/>

Research Traditions, Analysis, and Synthesis in Social Psychological Theories – The case of Dissonance Theory by Leonard Berkowitz, Patricia G Devine

The Oxford Handbook of Political Communication, Edited by Kate Kenski and Kathleen Hall Jamieson

Selective Exposure to Campaign Communication: The Role of Anticipated Agreement and Issue Public Membership by Shanto Iyengar, Kyu S Hahn, and others

http://methods.sowi.uni-mannheim.de/working_papers/ICA2012-Proposal.pdf

[http://www.academia.edu/35700432/Using_Open-](http://www.academia.edu/35700432/Using_Open-Source_Tools_to_Measure_Online_Selective_Exposure_in_Naturalistic_Settings)

[Source_Tools_to_Measure_Online_Selective_Exposure_in_Naturalistic_Settings](http://www.academia.edu/35700432/Using_Open-Source_Tools_to_Measure_Online_Selective_Exposure_in_Naturalistic_Settings)

Cantril, H. (1940) *The Invasion from Mars: A Study in the Psychology of Panic*. Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press.

Eswara, H. S. The contributions of Psychological Science to Media Research: An Historical Outline. *Journal of Media and Social Development*, 2016, 4 (1), Pp. 3-11. (Invited Paper prepared and accepted for presentation at a session of Indian Science Congress held at University of Mysore, January 3-7, 2016)

Feather, N.T. (1963). Cognitive dissonance, selectivity and evaluation. *Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology*, 66, pp. 157-163

Festinger, L. (1957) *A theory of cognitive dissonance*. Evanston, Ill.: Row-Peterson.

Hastorf, A.H., and Cantril, H. (1954) They saw the game: a case study. *The Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology*, 49, 129-134.

Hovland, C. I., I.L.Janis, & Kelley, H.H. (1953) *Communication and Persuasion*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Hovland, C.I., and I.L. Janis (Eds.) *Personality and Persuasibility*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Hyman, H.H. and Sheastlay (1947) Some reasons why information campaigns fail. *Public Opinion Quarterly*, 11 pp. 413-425.

Janis, I.L., (1954). Personality correlates of susceptibility to persuasion. *Journal of Personality*, 22, 504-518.

Janis, I.L., & P. B. Field (1959). Sex differences in personality factors related to persuasibility. In C.I. Hovland and I.L. Janis (Eds.) *Personality and Persuasibility* (Pp. 55-68). New Haven: Yale University Press.

Katz, E. and P. F. Lazarsfeld (1955). *Personal Influence: The Part Played by*

People in the Flow of Mass Communications. New York, N.Y., The Free Press.

Katz, E., Blumler, J.G., and Gurevitch, M. (1974) *The uses of mass communications: current perspectives on gratifications research*. Beverly Hills: Sage Publications.

Klapper, J. T. (1960) *The effects of Mass Communications*. Glencoe, Ill: Free Press.

Lazarsfeld, P.F., B. Berelson and H. Gaudet (1948) *The People's Choice*. New York: Columbia University Press.

McGuire, W.J. (1968) Personality and susceptibility to social influence. In E.E. Borgatta & W.W. Lambert, eds. *Handbook of personality theory and research*. Chicago: Rand McNally. Pp. 1130-1187

Petty, R. E., and Cacioppo, J.T (1966) *Advances in Experimental Social Psychology*, vol. 19. Pp.123-206.

Sherif, M. and C. I. Hovland (1961) *Social Judgment*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Vidmar, N., and Rokeach, M. (1974) Archie Bunker's bigotry: A study in selective perception and exposure. *Journal of Communication*, 24-47.